ON THE FOUNDATION

OF

# HUMANE ETHICS

BY

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Translated from the Danish

*Om Grundlaget for den humane Ethik.*

Kjøbenhavn: Andr. Fred. Høst & Søns Forlag, 1876

Was ist das Heiligste? — Das, was heut und ewig die Geister,
Tiefer und tiefer gefühlt, immer nur einiger macht.
Goethe.

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## Introduction.

*[1]* Although the great struggles of recent times between the various religious, social and political tendencies also concern ethical questions, one may nevertheless claim that, as regards the content of ethics, the law of duty itself, there prevails far greater uniformity and agreement than the opponents in the heat of the dispute are aware of. At the same stage of culture the general principles and rules of human action will, by the course of things, be the same for all. A common ground of humanity makes up the arena in which the struggle is fought. From this standpoint even the opposition between Christian and humane ethics disappears. "The Christian," says *Martensen*, "is in our day often hidden under the common human, and recognizable only on closer consideration." But what, then, is the dispute about? Partly about the further development and carrying through of what has already been attained, and partly about the deeper understanding and grounding of it. And here the relation is, more precisely, this: the spirit and direction in which the development is carried further will depend on the way in which one conceives and grounds the ethical as a whole. Here the great opposition between the different
*[2]* views of life makes itself felt. However much two people may agree about an ethical relation or a moral commandment, they may disagree just as much in their grounding of it. And yet in the ethical domain the grounding cannot be separated from the content. The way in which I ground my action will at the same time be an expression of the disposition with which it is carried out and of the motives that call it forth; and in the ethical domain it matters not only *what* I do, but also, indeed especially, *how* I do it. And although conscious thought can here, as little as anywhere else, give a complete picture of what stirs as moving motives in living feeling and energetic impulse, it is nevertheless a task that inquiring thought cannot push aside, to give itself an account of the foundation on which ethical action rests. To make a contribution to the elucidation of this question is the aim of this little book.

In practical life there is neither time for such deliberations nor direct use for them. The circumstances of life demand action, often immediate action. A choice must then be made in accordance with the best insight there is at hand. It is elements of very different origin that together make up the practical conviction which determines human action; and however important it is to undertake an exact investigation and evaluation of all these elements, such self-examination can in practice be undertaken only to a very

limited extent. Partly it presupposes a clear self-consciousness and a skill in psychological analysis that are given to few, and partly it is undertaken not with contemplative calm and disinterestedness, but under the influence of mighty feelings and passions. Every human being is a practical ethicist insofar as his striving must aim at bringing his action into harmony with the highest end and the highest law that he can recognize; but his endeavor toward the purification and deeper grounding of what is end and law for his action will soon be checked by limits that lie not only in his own individuality, but *[3]* also in the given social and historical conditions. A young Fiji Islander, for example, cannot conceive otherwise than that he gives his filial love its most fitting expression by taking his mother's life while she is still in her vigorous years, so that she shall not pass into the other world as one decrepit.[*)] A more far-reaching ethical criticism would here presuppose a break with the tribe's inherited belief in immortality. — A wider horizon we find in those whom one might call the prophetic ethicists, those personalities who, by virtue of a deep understanding of the conditions of the people and of the times and of the fundamental relations of human life as a whole, and by the power over men that their spiritual superiority gives them, are able to discover and spread new ethical laws, to create new forms and directions for ethical life. Great advances in an ethical direction often become possible only through such prophetic personalities, to whose number the great founders of religions, lawgivers and reformers belong. But despite the greater breadth and depth of these minds, there is nevertheless to be traced in them too the limitation that is inseparable from every striving directed toward particular practical ends. Their field of vision is conditioned by the historical presuppositions, by tradition, and by the nature of the people from which they spring and on which they are to work. Psychological and historical criticism, in them too, decidedly recedes into the shadow before the imperious demands of action.

If, then, the task we have put forward — to find the elements of the ethical and the law of their combination, — is to be treated at all, another standpoint must be taken. The theoretical ethicist relates himself in a purely investigative way to what the practical and the prophetic ethicist always grasps only in immediate relation to practical action. *[4]* If the practical ethicist is the sailor and the prophetic ethicist the helmsman, then the theoretical ethicist is the astronomer, who from his, at least relatively, fixed station is able to make observations and investigations of quite another certainty and exactness than those who battle with wind and wave. There is no presumption in the position of the theoretical ethicist toward the other two; if he sees more clearly, it is only because he

[*)] See the conversation between the young Fiji Islander and the missionary in *Lubbock*: Origin of civilisation p. 368.

moves in the world of ideal conceptions instead of in full-bodied reality, and if he would set his theoretical insight above the energetic conviction that they have attained by the practical way, he must remember the well-known verse: "To understand a chart is one thing, another to steer a ship!" — The theoretical ethicist brings no other presuppositions to the subject he would investigate than any other inquirer. What matters first and foremost is to grasp the object one has chosen in its characteristic peculiarity, to find the most fitting expression for it. As regards the ethical, then, the first thing will be a description of the psychological state, the relation and the disposition, that rightly bears its name. The next is to separate out the elements of which this fundamental form consists and to show the sources from which they derive; in this way ethical life will at the same time be seen in its connection with human life and the life of the world as a whole. Theoretical ethics is thus an empirical science, built on psychology and history. It proceeds from the observation of action as actually given and infers from it to general laws. But it cannot remain standing at the empirical. Every scientific cognition is an ideal construction, which grasps the elements given in experience while passing over all disturbing and inessential circumstances. Thus, e.g., Kepler's laws are ideals to which
*[5]* the actual motions of the planets correspond only approximately. By abstracting — i.e., by disregarding all incidental circumstances — one at the same time idealizes, i.e., one forms a picture of the matter as it would be under certain simple presuppositions and without the disturbing interference of other conditions. In this way theoretical ethics also forms an ideal type, an expression of human action as it would be in its perfection. The consistency and purity with which such a type is developed have a purifying and clarifying effect back upon the intricate conditions of actual life; and even if it would be doctrinaire fantasy to apply such a standard directly under certain given conditions, it is nevertheless of great importance to become aware in which direction the movement must go. The conception of the actual and the conception of the ideal thus serve each other for mutual enrichment: the actual is explained and illuminated and is thereby raised to a higher stage; the ideal receives closer, more concrete determinations and is thereby brought nearer to realization.

## Psychological Remarks.

Our sensations and ideas arise in us as symbols of the nature and relations of things. *[7]* When we perceive or imagine something, we look away from ourselves and become absorbed in the contemplation of the object, and the more we are able to do this, the clearer and more exact the conception we gain. But every sensation and idea also acts back upon our consciousness, intervenes in one way or another in our whole mental state, produces a certain mood or feeling: — if our conscious life as a whole is furthered and heightened, a feeling of pleasure, — if it is hindered and weakened, a feeling of pain. These moods can often be wholly subordinate in relation to the outward-directed side of the sensation or idea; the more they gain the upper hand, the less energetic and clear the conception of things becomes. He who is moved by pleasure or pain is no longer an impartial observer, and conversely, in order to make observations, pleasure and pain *[8]* must be pushed back. There is thus an inverse relation between cognition and feeling; the two cannot both stand at their highest point at the same time, but the highest degree of the one presupposes the lowest degree of the other.

To everything that calls forth a heightening of the mental state, and thus a feeling of pleasure, we ascribe a certain value, which originally shows itself in our involuntarily seeking to hold fast the idea of it and to move toward it. The sensation and the idea in themselves contain no ground for movement; it is only through its relation to our mental life as a whole, thus through the feeling it awakens, that a cognition calls forth movement and action, and since an inverse relation obtains between cognition and feeling, there must also be an inverse relation between cognition and action.

But this is only one side of the matter. In the preceding remarks we have taken account only of the *degree of strength*. If, on the other hand, we ask about that by which the feeling is awakened and toward which the movement is directed, thus about the *content*, it will turn out that cognition and feeling, cognition and action, no longer stand in an inverse but in a direct relation to each other. A feeling of pleasure leads us to hold fast the idea, or to continue the movement, that calls it forth. But when certain ideas and movements now turn out to stand in close connection with one another, the one leading to the other as cause to effect, or there is great similarity and kinship between them, *[9]* then the feeling will gradually be extended to all such ideas as belong together. There then forms a comprehensive world of objects to which the individual attaches value,

because they directly or indirectly awaken and heighten mental life. On the content of this world it depends in which direction the individual's life and action will go. Every higher stage that is reached in the development of knowledge will therefore necessarily act back upon the life of feeling and of action. Quietly, but without interruption, feeling moves up in the footsteps of thought, becomes nuanced, made precise and enriched. The higher and richer the life of thought, the deeper and fuller, therefore, the life of feeling can also be. Many feelings that the civilized European knows are foreign to the savage because of his little-developed circle of ideas, and the feelings that they have in common have a different character in each of them.

When experience has attained a certain range and knowledge a certain development, action takes account not merely of the immediate and present feelings of pleasure and pain, but also of the possible and more remote ones. But this already presupposes a stage of development to which several savage peoples have scarcely raised themselves. They fill themselves with food and drink when they have abundance, without thinking of the harmful consequences of gluttony or of the lack of food that will soon succeed the abundance. They think only of the momentary satisfaction. Only need brings them
*[10]* to work again, and so they go on in the same cycle. Only when conscious life reaches a certain development, in strength as well as in range, can memories and expectations determine the mode of action, even when it is counteracted by the momentary pleasure or pain; and we have here the first trace of a rule for action lying beyond what is immediately given and present. And at the same time we have here the first clear appearance of a real will, in the energy with which the momentary promptings are pushed back so that the motives that have proved to be of more essential importance for the individual's weal and woe can assert themselves. In all attention there is something of a willing, but this appears most clearly in the domain of action, as soon as experience has called forth a consciousness of the different consequences of actions for man.

Attempts have often been made to reduce attention and all manifestations of the will to mere modifications of sensations and ideas, a kind of condensation of these. On the contrary, recent physiology and psychology have led to the result that movement precedes sensation and is a more primitive expression of our nature than the latter. At the stage of conscious life it seems, at least, as if movements and actions were guided by definite motives and purposes. But if we go back to the stage where there is as yet no question of conscious sensations and ideas, to the child in the mother's womb, then its voluntary movements cannot be derived from any purpose, cannot be determined
*[11]* by any idea, but have a purely spontaneous character. "It moves," as Johannes Müller

says, "its limbs not in order to attain an external end, but only because it can move them."*) Only gradually, then, do the experiences made in this way lead to guiding the following movements in certain directions, and finally the idea of the possible movement can precede the actual movement and call it forth. But the very manner in which the original spontaneous movement takes place will be conditioned by the individual's innate organization, and from this it is again seen to how high a degree the direction and character of the individual's action must depend on the nature that it receives as an inheritance from its ancestors. Individual action here goes back into the action of the whole race and is determined by it. For it is not only at the beginning of individual life that spontaneous movement plays a part; all that we call instinctive action must be referred to it. These are actions that we perform without knowing why, and whose real character we only later become conscious of, just as the young bird sets its vocal organs in motion without knowing what it is doing, and only afterwards learns to know its own notes. And even when conscious motives assert themselves, everyone nevertheless knows from his own experience cases in which neither any single one of these motives *[12]* nor all of them together contain the sufficient explanation of the action; one must then here go back to the deeper instinct, whether this has formed itself as a second nature in the course of the individual's life or springs from the original organization.

The proposition that all action springs from pleasure or pain is thus only partly true; man does not always act on motives, because he does not always act with consciousness. It is important to hold fast to this, since otherwise one will arrive at a false conception of human willing and acting at its primitive stage. For the proposition about pleasure and pain as the fundamental motives of action has often been used to prove that egoism is the deepest impulse in human nature. But real egoism presupposes a reflection, a calculation, and thus a development of the understanding, of which there is as yet no question at the primitive stages. Instinctive self-preservation cannot rightly be called egoism. Only at a higher stage of development can the individual tear itself loose from the connection in which it originally stands, make itself the center and reduce everything else to a means. Originally the individual does not make this distinction, does not distinguish between pleasure and pain and that which calls them forth, but believes that in the pleasure or the pain itself it comes to know the nature of things. On this rests precisely the fact that man can be educated; through the power of changing moods he can be led beyond his original limitation, which would not be possible if he had really isolated himself in *[13]*

*) *Joh. Müller*: "Handbuch der Physiologie" (I. p. 94). *Alex. Bain* has in his work "The senses and the intellect" (Book I) more fully developed and grounded the doctrine of spontaneous movement, which, moreover, one will already find in *Descartes*, in his "Traité des passions" (I. 10—11., II. 107).

himself from the beginning.

Just as little as our physical world-system could have developed out of the original nebulous mass if the repulsive force had been the only one prevailing, just as little would the world of humanity have come into being if only one single impulse, the isolating impulse of self-preservation, had ruled in human nature. In this nature too a plurality of forces is at work. There lies in it a predisposition to sympathy just as much as to egoism; there is in our nature "something of the dove beside the serpent and the wolf." We find sympathetic impulses already within the animal world, in the parents' love for and self-sacrifice for their young, and in the cohesion between individuals of the same flock. In man these impulses are developed and enriched like all others, as spiritual development advances. Involuntary compassion and fellow-feeling with others cannot be derived from any calculation of what consequences their happiness or unhappiness may have for us. Sympathy presupposes only that we ourselves know from experience what pleasure and pain are, and that we really regard others as beings of the same kind as ourselves. We involuntarily put ourselves in their place, make their feelings our own. The extent to which sympathy asserts itself depends on how far the consciousness of community reaches. Sympathetic feeling has its original hearth in the family relation,
*[14]* and among very crude tribes it can easily look, even here, as if it were overshadowed by the tyrannical impulse of self-preservation, the individual, in a desperate struggle to subsist, raging blindly against everything that stands in its way, insofar as superior force does not hold it in check. But sympathy is in itself just as natural to man as the family relation is, and just as the human race would perish if this relation ceased, the same would happen if all sympathy were lacking. From the narrower circle of the family it spreads at last to the people, the tribe, and at last to the whole of humanity.

Both by following the promptings of the impulse of self-preservation and by following those of sympathy, man is led to regard himself as a member of a greater whole. Whether his impulses are satisfied or meet resistance, he receives an impression of definite conditions and fixed connection, of an order of things under which he must bow. It is, as we have remarked, the development of knowledge that makes a further development of the feelings possible. But knowledge does not stand merely as a serving instrument. It itself makes essential contributions to the character of action. It sets up general laws and rules, carries through one point of view consistently. Feeling and passion have a tendency to make exceptions, to act irregularly and only in particular directions. Developed knowledge makes action consistent and directs it toward one essential end. The individual senses in the known truth an authority that stands untouched by his

wishes and impulses; he has in it a fixed point to which he can take refuge in order to *[15]* win an impartial conception of his conditions and his conduct. The personal life needs to be purified by the impersonal truth, raised above all arbitrariness and contingency.

From what has now been developed we draw some general conclusions, which will lead us nearer to our proper subject. For man to come to act, there must in the first place be a sufficiently strong occasion for it. The strength of the occasion here means the degree to which man's nature is disposed to action at a given moment, and such a disposition can, as we have seen, be either an original instinct, an unconscious impulse, or a feeling of pleasure or pain awakened by certain sensations and ideas. But in the second place we have seen that experience and knowledge have a great influence on what awakens pleasure and pain, and that man in his action is determined by the greater whole of which he is a member, and which he can embrace with disinterested sympathy. So far as we look merely to the *strength* of what drives man to action, we seem to have to do only with himself; but the *content and end* of action point us beyond the single individuals. The question now is whether in any of the psychological laws brought out here we have starting points for the conception and grounding of the ethical.

That the ethical does not rest on the strength of what leads to action will easily be seen. Strong feelings and instincts are immediate expressions of the individual's temperament and innate character. It can be an advantage, in an ethical respect too, to *[16]* be equipped with strong natural impulses, but no one will immediately find the essence of the ethical in them. All will agree that the ethical always presupposes a law, a rule, an end, which does not immediately coincide with impulse or instinct. It is with the good as with the true. We do not call an idea or an opinion true until we have convinced ourselves of its agreement with the real, according to the standard that we possess in this respect. And neither do we call an action good except insofar as it accords with the general rule which in our opinion ought to hold in human life. Here, then, a higher law or standard is presupposed in both places. We are thus referred over to the other side of human action, — its content and end. Nor will one here immediately find the ethical. There certainly lies, as we have seen earlier, already in man's immediate nature a capacity to devote himself and to recognize something that lies beyond his own individual self. But only when this recognition becomes conscious will it receive the name of ethical. And this will then be precisely the most general determination that we can set up of ethical action: an action whose motives are ideas and feelings that point beyond the individual self and attest that the individual sees himself as a member of a more comprehensive order of things, whose end he makes his own and whose law he regards as the rule for

*[17]* his life. The Greek word from which the expression "ethical" is formed, like the Latin word from which the synonymous expression "moral" comes, means custom and usage; in the Danish word "Sædelighed" we have the same basic meaning. By these expressions we are pointed to a general law and rule by which the individual's action directs itself, but it does not properly lie in them that this law is the object of his living feeling and assent. Mere habituation certainly binds the single person to a greater whole, but can in itself very well have a purely mechanical origin. Custom is not yet morality.

Whether this general definition of ethical action, as motivated by recognition of a higher law and reverence for it, is correct will only gradually become apparent in the course of our following investigations. Only in the course of these, likewise, will there be a question of the nature of the higher law, and of how far we can speak at all of a universally valid ethical law, as well as of the relation between it and the various laws by which men at various times and in various places have felt themselves bound.

The provisional determination of the foundation of the ethical that we have set up will in what follows be supported first by a more indirect, then by a more direct argument. For in the first place we shall examine the justification of the attempts that have been made to derive the ethical from one or more of the individual starting points
*[18]* brought out in the foregoing: the pure impulse of self-preservation, sympathy, and reason. If these elements contain the full foundation of the ethical, our definition will be incorrect; if, on the other hand, those attempts prove to be incomplete, it will gain an indirect confirmation; for if the foundation of the ethical cannot be sought in the purely individual, it must be sought in the relation in which the individual stands to a higher power. The second thing we have to do will then be to show how such a relation to a higher power comes into being, and how the recognition and reverence develop in which we see the properly ethical motive. — The first series of investigations will thus concern individuality, the second authority.

## Individual Starting Points.

1. We have already seen in the foregoing that it was only wrongly that one could *[19]* designate man's action, as determined by pleasure and pain, as egoistic. When one tries to derive the ethical from the impulse toward happiness, from man's original striving for well-being, one need not therefore deny that there are other feelings and impulses in human nature than the egoistic ones. It is enough if one starts from what no one can well deny, that these are from the first the strongest. In order, then, to find a really firm and reliable ground on which to build the ethical, one turns to the original fundamental impulse, which in various forms must find its satisfaction in every human action. Here one is sure of commanding sufficiently weighty motives; one appeals to individual interest and seeks to show that ethical action is only a particular way of satisfying this *[20]* interest. The ethical is interest well understood.

In antiquity this standpoint was represented by *Aristippus* and *Epicurus*. The individual's feeling of pleasure and pain is for them the foundation and principle of all action. *Aristippus* designated pleasure more precisely as momentary enjoyment. The task for him then became to possess such a virtuosity that one can at every moment take an enjoying attitude. But this isolation of the moment from past and future soon proved impossible to carry through, just as that virtuosity is the affair of only few mortals, who combine fortunate outward conditions with mental mobility and a sanguine temperament. Epicurus therefore did not start from momentary pleasure, but saw the foundation of right action in man's longing for happiness in the sense of a lasting contentment secured by prudence, which presupposes resignation in the face of the unavoidable pains. The lesser is sacrificed to the greater, the shorter to the more lasting. While Aristippus gladly gave himself up to the present, Epicurus withdrew into himself, in quiet enjoyment of the peace within him, the unrest of passion being subdued by rational deliberation, and the fear of the unexpected and of the supernatural removed by insight into the necessary laws of nature. The Epicurean joins himself to other men only in order to heighten his enjoyment by sharing it with his friends. Social life arises from the mutual utility men can render one another; it procures security and is thus a necessary condition of the wise man's happiness, since he would otherwise live in a constant unrest and would be *[21]* drawn away from himself into strenuous activity directed outward.

The kindred tendencies that have appeared in modern times have, despite the common starting point, two characteristic peculiarities. The main thing is no longer to procure for the individual an idyllic refuge where he can enjoy life in peace, but the satisfaction of a restless craving for progress. Characters like Hobbes and Bentham have little in common with Aristippus and Epicurus; they are polemicists and reformers. Connected with this, too, is the fact that they think far less of the happiness of the single individual than of that of all individuals. It was natural for Aristippus and Epicurus to withdraw into the individual self, since they lived in a period in which public interest had faded and the period of dissolution of a whole culture had begun. But it was just as natural for men of a kindred tendency in modern times, when cultural and social life is in vigorous advance and new forces and ideas are stirring, to adopt a more comprehensive point of view.

The first good, the one pointed out by nature itself, is according to *Hobbes* self-preservation. All strive to preserve and enjoy life and to avoid death, especially a painful death. From this first good other goods can be derived. Thus power, wealth, friendship and wisdom are goods, because they serve the preservation and enjoyment of life. A highest good, an absolute end, cannot be conceived; it would be a state in which all
*[22]* opposition and movement had ceased; but then no enjoyment, not even any perception, would be possible, since all sensation presupposes alternation and plurality. The greatest happiness consists in advancing, with as few hindrances as possible, toward higher and more remote ends.

Since the impulse of self-preservation is equally strong in all, but the one often stands in the other's way, men live, says Hobbes, in a constant fear of one another. The weak fear the power of the strong; the strong fear the cunning of the weak. The only means to security is to forestall the other by depriving him of the capacity to do harm. Thus arises a war of all against all. Men are like raging wolves toward one another. In this condition no culture, no true human life, can develop. Man's capacity to cast his gaze out into the future only makes him unhappier than the animal. Fear and anxiety awaken ever anew, just as Prometheus' liver grew again in the night after being devoured in the day. Now when reason develops, it teaches man that the state of war is a source of all his misery and therefore ought to be avoided at any price. Peace is thus a good about whose value all can agree; it accords with the interest of all and leads them beyond the miseries of the state of nature. Reason enjoins the natural laws that men must follow if they would work their way out of the original animal condition. These laws set bounds to individual freedom, to the immediate influence of the passions, and enjoin certain virtues

as necessary means to a peaceful life. Such virtues are justice, gratitude, placability, *[23]* compassion, etc. — But in order that the natural laws should be more than mere precepts and doctrines and be able to come forward with sufficient authority against the unruly impulses, all must submit to a common sovereign, an absolute authority, before which each of them entirely gives up his own will. The law of nature, which prescribes the means for the satisfaction of the impulse of self-preservation, therefore also prescribes complete submission to the will of the power of the state as the only means of securing peace.

*Bentham* is not pessimistic like Hobbes; he does not consider it necessary to hog-tie men so that they shall not tear one another to pieces like wild beasts; but he nevertheless holds fast to the impulse toward happiness as the only foundation of the ethical. Against this impulse all talk of duty and self-sacrifice is only empty words; how should such phrases be able to overcome the mightiest craving, the one most deeply grounded in our being? And on the other hand, what kind of virtue would that be which in no respect whatever contributed to furthering human happiness? And even if there were such a virtue, by what motives would one then be able to get men to strive for it? One must reduce all questions of good and evil to questions of pleasure and pain; only then can one arrive at a sure and definite valuation. From the simple opposition between pleasure and pain all ethical virtues, all ethical relations, can be grounded. Give me joy and sorrow, *[24]* pleasure and pain, and I will create an ethical world!

Since the fundamental impulse in man is originally directed toward happiness, it is merely a matter of guiding it rightly; for from shortsightedness and faulty calculation man often misses what he seeks. The task of ethics, then, is to teach man to calculate correctly. He must learn to sacrifice the lesser for the greater. Only such sacrifices can be defended as increase pleasure or diminish pain, now or in the future. Prudence therefore becomes the first, or properly the only, virtue. Moderation and self-control stand in close connection with it. Not every striving for happiness or utility, however, deserves to be called virtuous; for a striving to bear this name, it must be bound up with effort and have a resistance to overcome. The effort consists in holding fast the insight one has gained into what brings pleasure and pain, against the promptings of the moment. An unethical action rests on a faulty calculation of personal interest; but the individual has not only his own interests to take into account. In order to be able rightly to reach his own goal he must serve the interests of others. A great part of his joys and enjoyments rests on the will of others, and he can secure their cooperation only by himself working for their wishes. It is personal interest itself, the strongest of all bonds, that ties the single

individual to the whole race. Do not imagine that men will move the tip of their finger
[25] to serve you when they can have no advantage from it; it has never happened and will never happen, as long as human nature is as it now is. But men will wish to serve you when they find their advantage in it, and there are countless occasions on which they can be of use to you at the same time as they are of use to themselves. Such occasions the understanding discovers, but the multitude does not notice them. In these mutual services virtue consists. — Beside prudence as the chief virtue is thus set calculating benevolence. But Bentham expressly insists that love of oneself lies at the basis of love of others, or, as he expresses it, that the social principle is subordinate to the personal principle. Ethics, as Bentham conceives it, could be defined as the doctrine of the detours men are compelled to make in order to satisfy their striving for happiness. The most important of these detours is conditioned by regard for others. Bentham lays such great weight on this point that he sets up as a general principle: the greatest possible happiness for the greatest possible number of men! This principle does not cancel the command of personal prudence; for the happiness of each single individual is, after all, just as much a part of the common sum of happiness as that of all others. The principle is thus fulfilled no better than when each, for his own part, procures for himself as much happiness as possible.

Bentham polemicizes vehemently against words like "duty" and "ought," because
[26] in his opinion they favor ungrounded commands of authority. When one has declared that something is a duty or ought to happen, one regards the matter as settled without grounding it further. But there is a little word that has remedied the harm those words have done: it is the word *why*. If only one goes on using this, one will, Bentham hopes, put an end to the belief in authority and to the dominion of mystical inspirations in ethics. And here he really has a great merit. He has, as energetically as perhaps no other ethicist, demanded grounds for each single ethical command. He has further shown the close connection between the belief in authority and asceticism; both are equally tyrannical toward human nature, and mutilate it each in its own way. Finally, in his principle of the greatest possible happiness for all he has set up a standard for practical reforms which has already proved its great significance. But the central ethical relation he has no eye for in his theory. If there is anything an ethicist should occupy himself with investigating, it must be the very concept of obligation. That Bentham wants to expel this from ethics has its natural ground in the fact that this concept can find no place in his own conception; for one need not, after all, be obligated to what one immediately and involuntarily strives for. On the other hand, Bentham does not refrain from using both the word "duty" and

the word "ought" when he wants to enjoin the virtues of prudence and benevolence. And the only sanction he can then point to as the foundation of obligation becomes the fear of punishment, either criminal punishment or the condemnation of public opinion. *[27]* Here, like Hobbes, he appeals to fear as the final motive.

The general psychological investigations we have undertaken earlier furnish the necessary elements for an assessment of the attempts now set forth. What Bentham (we keep to him, since he has given the theory its most finished form) presupposes is that man's action takes place only according to conscious motives that can be weighed mechanically against one another. He overlooks the deeper connection between the single individual and the whole race from which it springs and in whose midst it lives. According to Bentham's doctrine it is only personal interest that binds men together. Although he does not share Hobbes' doctrine of the original contract, by which social life was founded so that each individual might gain security and peace, he nevertheless still stands in principle on the same standpoint. Society and the race are for him only a result, a mechanical aggregate of individuals, not also the maternal womb from which these spring. But Hobbes himself had already become aware that there was, after all, one society that could not be explained in this way, could not have arisen from the individual arbitrary choice of the parties, namely the society of the family, especially the society between mother and child. Here not only does an immediate sympathetic instinct assert itself, but we have here also a relation in which authority can in no way be a consequence of contract. The child stands immediately under the mother's authority, or, as Hobbes expresses it in his language, there can be no son in the state of nature. *[28]* Man thus in reality never begins entirely from the beginning, and already in this lies a hint that ethics too, the doctrine of right human action, cannot be grounded deeply enough by taking a purely individualistic starting point. Man, as enjoying and suffering, makes everything a means for himself, directly or indirectly; but the ethical relation first arises when man feels himself not merely as end but as means, not merely as master but as servant, — means and servant for ends that are more comprehensive than his own individual pleasure and pain. This does not conflict with what Bentham, with such great right, emphasizes against ascetic ethics, that no sacrifice has value and can be defended that does not produce more happiness than is sacrificed. For because the individual's happiness cannot be the foundation of the ethical relation, it is not thereby said that the ethical stands hostile to it. It might well be that the highest happiness, the fullest unfolding of man's capacities and powers, precisely presupposes that he stands in the service of a higher cause and wholly gives himself up to it without anxiously heeding

his own individual pleasure or pain.

Only when the question is not of the foundation of ethics but of its content does Bentham's greatness show itself. It is a great philanthropic and reformatory principle that he has set up in the proposition of the greatest possible happiness for all. His
*[29]* doctrine is rather a theory of right legislation than an ethical theory. Legislation must always strive to bring about a harmony between individual interests. It looks to the result, not to the motive. Thus Bentham also teaches that it is the action itself and its consequences, not the motive, that matter. All motives are, after all, in his view only different forms of one and the same fundamental impulse; men act only to obtain pleasure and avoid pain; in this, then, all actions agree, whereas their consequences are very different. Nevertheless, it is not the consequences in themselves either that, in Bentham's view, make an action ethical or unethical; he calls only that action virtuous in which a more comprehensive cognition, and not the momentary prompting, is the determining ground; virtue presupposes effort. He thus himself goes back to the motive (of which regard for the consequences must of course always be a part), and confirms the provisional definition of ethical action that we have set up, in that he too demands a higher law as determining the action, only that this law, in his view, springs from the impulse toward happiness itself, is a direct interpretation of its demands. But this is too narrow a standpoint.[*)]

*[30]* It might seem as if the doctrine of the impulse toward happiness as the foundation of ethical action were confirmed by *Darwin's* well-known doctrine of the struggle for existence. Like the plant and the animal, man too reaches the highest development of his being only through the labor of preserving and sustaining life. It is a fact that culture and social life are to a great extent possible only through the interaction of interests. It is the never-resting striving for a higher and more lasting enjoyment of life that leads to new labors and discoveries; the savage is held back at a lower stage of culture by his few and simple needs. But however high a stage of culture one presupposes, life is nevertheless always a struggle to survive. At any moment the simple question of being or not being can be posed, and the impulse of self-preservation can then express itself

[*)] In the defense that Stuart Mill has made of "Utilitarianism," or the ethics grounded on the impulse toward happiness, he has, as I have shown elsewhere (Den engelske Filosophi i vor Tid, p. 51—58), so transformed this doctrine that he almost no longer defends what its opponents have attacked. There are two points in particular in which he departs from Bentham. He abandons the doctrine of Bentham and of the oldest utilitarians, that all pleasures are alike in kind and differ only in strength and duration, and distinguishes between higher and lower enjoyments. But since the standard for this difference in value cannot be sought in the enjoyment itself, utilitarianism is properly abandoned with this. He next lays far greater weight on the sympathetic feelings and sees in them the proper foundation of the ethical, whereby he gives up the purely individualistic starting point that was the sole ruling one in Bentham.

in all its brutal nakedness. Thus, e.g., on board a ship that is burning on the open sea, and where the crew seize the boats while the passengers fight for life and death over the life belts. The strongest and the most ruthless will here most easily escape. What only a single terrible event calls forth among civilized men is standing custom among savages, *[31]* who, like the animals, rid themselves of sick and decrepit individuals.

What must first be remarked is that, even if egoism were the only motive in the struggle for existence, this circumstance would nevertheless not furnish a sufficient reason for deriving the ethical law from egoism; the question would then be precisely whether there was no way of getting beyond egoism. But one must not stare oneself blind at examples of brutality, especially since one could set against them examples of heroic and disinterested self-sacrifice.[*)] The struggle for existence means essentially the struggle to preserve the particular form of existence one has attained. The further development advances, the less it is bare existence that is at stake; men have their life in certain *forms* which they cannot or will not give up, forms that stand as the expression of the human, and whose preservation and development is the end of the struggle. The struggle is for the upholding of all the true, the beautiful and the good that the human *[32]* race has produced in the course of its life. He who sacrifices himself for an ideal end, his art or his science, or he who lays down his life to save another, fights just as much for life as the egoist who sacrifices everything and everyone for his own advantage. The political economists speak of an accustomed mode of living, a "standard of life," as the sum of the demands that the workers make on life, and at whose level they struggle to maintain themselves. In an ethical respect too there is a "standard of life," and it is really its preservation that the struggle is about. Man always fights to uphold what is for him the highest, and to which he has attached his whole personality. One has no right to look only to the most elementary and brutal forms of the struggle for life. To come to know the nature of man, one must not merely study it at a single stage of development, but follow it through all the different stages, and in the law that holds for the course of development from the lowest of these stages to the highest one will have the full expression of human nature. The cabbage caterpillar and the butterfly are the same animal at different stages, and only in the law of the development from the one stage to the other does one have this animal's nature expressed.

[*)] On the 23rd of December 1871 the steamship "Amerika" burned on the voyage from Buenos Ayres to Montevideo. The captain had at once jumped overboard with a life belt around his body; the crew saved themselves in a boat. The passengers had only the choice between death in the flames or in the waves. People fought with dagger and revolver over the life belts. A wretch killed a young, helpless wife in order to seize her life belt, while another passenger, Louis Viala, voluntarily gave up his to a young woman. The wretch was saved; Viala perished. (Berlingske Tidende 3rd Feb. 1872).

2. Over against the attempts to derive the ethical from the impulse toward happiness we now set the attempts that have been made to derive it from natural sympathy. In
[33] antiquity the *Stoics* brought forward this starting point, showing how love of mankind has its source in parents' love for their children, from which it gradually spreads in wider and wider circles, embraces the whole people, indeed at last the whole human race. Just as we use our limbs before we have learned for what use we have been given them, so we have received from the very hand of nature an impulse toward community with others. In modern times this doctrine has been further developed by *Shaftesbury*, Hume and *Adam Smith*, and in our own day by *Auguste Comte*, *Darwin* and *Spencer*. In the two last named it is brought into connection with the hypothesis of evolution.

When man immediately and instinctively shares in the weal and woe of others and from his very birth is a member of a society, then the preservation of society will also stand as an end for the individual. Already among the animals we find strong social impulses. Darwin cites, after Brehm, the incident that, when a troop of baboons was put to flight by travelers throwing stones, some of the strongest males turned back several times to rescue, at the risk of their lives, the young that could not keep up. Such social impulses are developed by natural selection. The animals that help one another gain an advantage in the struggle for life over those that fight in isolation. Through inheritance and constant exercise the social interests are developed ever further; and since the survival of the race depends on them, they will as a rule be the strongest; they work quietly, but without interruption, even if at particular moments they are pushed back by the egoistic impulse of self-preservation and of happiness. When the individual,
[34] after having thus succumbed to temptation, has come back to its normal state, it will notice that a more lasting and more deeply grounded instinct has been hindered in its activity. Already in the animal, therefore, one can speak of remorse; yet only man can be called a moral being, because he has the capacity to make comparisons between his past and future actions or motives and to approve or disapprove of them. One can often observe in animals a struggle between instincts, e.g., in the dog between obedience to its master and love for its puppies, in the swallow between maternal love and the migratory impulse. "As long as the mother swallow is feeding her young or brooding over them, maternal love is probably stronger than the migratory instinct; but the instinct that is the more persistent wins the victory, and at last, when her young are for a moment out of sight, she takes flight and deserts them. What scruples of conscience would not each single bird feel if, when it had come to the end of its journey and the migratory instinct no longer worked, it were endowed with so great a liveliness of mind that it

could not prevent there constantly passing before its soul an image of its young, dying in the wintry north of hunger and cold!"[*)] Man's intellectual capacities are now precisely so developed that earlier impressions and images constantly pass before his soul, so that he cannot avoid making comparisons; only he, therefore, can feel real remorse; it *[35]* awakens in him a sharpened feeling of duty, i.e., of obedience to the most deeply lying and constantly working instinct in his nature; that there is something man *ought* to do means that he has a consciousness of the existence of a persistent instinct which serves him as a guide, but is, to be sure, liable not to be obeyed.

Just as, according to Bentham's doctrine, not every satisfaction of the impulse toward happiness could be called ethical, but only that in which man followed the prudent calculation of the understanding despite the momentary prompting, so the adherents of the morality of sympathy cannot regard every action from sympathetic impulse as ethical either. Tacitus relates of the ancient Germans that, although they took pleasure in gifts, they thought neither that they owed gratitude when they had received them nor that they had any claim when they had given them. And likewise it is related of some Indian tribes that they acted from affection just as they acted from desire, without regard to the consequences. When they had shown another a kindness, they had satisfied an impulse; the matter was finished and vanished from memory; but conversely they felt no regret either at having satisfied their selfish passions; both in their sympathy and in their egoism they acted as true children of the moment. Here again it is shown that the ethical presupposes a model, a law, which lies beyond the mood of the moment and points toward a more comprehensive and fixed form for human life. Therefore Darwin and his *[36]* predecessors emphasize the significance of memory and thought. With them it stands not in the service of the impulse toward happiness, but in that of sympathy, and holds fast its demands against the claims of the impulse of self-preservation and of egoism. The personal principle is here subordinate to the social. Through the purifying and illuminating power of cognition the sympathies can gradually be freed from their limits, go beyond the narrower circles of the family and the nation, and become a disinterested love for all living beings.

Bentham and the utilitarians too could point to a great social connection in which the individual stood in an ethical respect. All that belongs to the sustaining of human life and to the satisfaction of its needs is not brought about anew within each single generation, but each new generation works on the basis of fixed institutions, forms and traditions which it inherits from earlier generations. Culture rests on tradition. It is

[*)] *Darwin*: Om Menneskets Oprindelse. Danish trans. I. p. 86.

not only by his reason, his capacity to combine and foresee, that man raises himself above the animal; progress would not be great if each had to begin from the beginning. Language and tradition make possible the accumulation and diffusion of inventions and discoveries. The system of interests to which utilitarianism refers thus embraces not only all men living at the same time, but also the countless series of earlier generations. As beings of culture we are bound in solidarity with our predecessors. But according to
*[37]* the morality of utility, culture is only an outward connection connection, into which the individual lives himself because he finds his own interests satisfied by working toward its consolidation and development. Bentham and his school do not look to the influence that culture, according to the general laws of life, has and must have on human nature itself. Human nature is developed and transformed through the work of cultural history. With the changed conditions of life the original impulses and predispositions will also gradually change. Not only through external tradition does the individual come to share in what the race has acquired; in his innermost nature he carries the after-effects of the exertions of the past, according to the general physiological law that function acts back upon organization. The original conditions of men had to make them egoists; the milder forms that the struggle for life gradually assumes must also make human nature milder. The great spokesmen of the hypothesis of evolution, Darwin and Spencer, therefore come forward against Bentham, Mill and Bain.[*)] Whereas the utilitarians presuppose the impulse toward happiness as equally strong at all times, the starting point of the morality of sympathy is not a constant magnitude, but varies
*[38]* continually. The sympathetic impulse has its deepest foundation, as has been indicated several times, in the maternal instinct. Auguste Comte therefore finds the first trace of moral and social life at the point within the animal world where hermaphroditism has ceased and the sexes are separated. From the family relation it then spreads in wider and wider circles. The purely empirical conception cannot sufficiently ground this quiet growth of sympathy. Hartley, to be sure, and after him in our day Stuart Mill, have rightly emphasized that by virtue of the laws of the association of ideas man will come to love for its own sake that which he was at first interested in only because it satisfied his self-love, just as we involuntarily ascribe to money a significance and a value that properly belong only to what we can obtain for the money. He who is constantly compelled to work together with others in order to attain his own ends will

[*)] *Herbert Spencer* wrote in the year 1846 an essay on sympathy in the same direction as Adam Smith's "Theory of moral sentiments," which he did not know at the time. In 1850 his "Social Statics" appeared, where the same subject is treated. He also comes back to it at the end of his Psychology, but his "Principles of morality" are only to form the conclusion of his great work.

gradually forget his original motive and feel a disinterested interest in the welfare of others and in the common goal. The art of education consists precisely in attaching the individual's pleasure and pain to the right objects, binding his interest to them in such a way that he can at last be wholly absorbed in them. But the hypothesis of evolution teaches us that it is not education and individual experience that are to do everything here. The sympathetic impulse is not merely a product of the associations of ideas. It grows through the generations, since the ever more frequent occasion to express itself, and the ever more comprehensive circle within which it moves, must necessarily also strengthen the predisposition in individuals to let themselves be governed by it. Quietly *[39]* and imperceptibly, then, according to this hypothesis, a metamorphosis of human nature takes place. Every enthusiastic mood, every noble and philanthropic feeling adds an atom to the building of the perfect humanity. Nothing is lost, in spiritual nature any more than in bodily nature.

The ethical law, as it takes shape from the standpoint of the morality of sympathy, would have as its content the development of perfect, comprehensive love of humanity. But the question cannot be kept away, wherein the ethical element in sympathy really lies. As an immediate impulse it can attach itself just as well to the worthless or even the corrupting as to the good and right. Adam Smith himself remarks (what would perhaps no longer fit our day) that the great mass is a disinterested admirer of everything unusual, especially great power and wealth. Love is, after all, on the whole blind. In order to make others happy it must have a model, an ideal of happiness, of perfected human life, toward which it can then seek to lead others. But this it can have only when thought is more than the deputy of sympathy and can really come forward as an ordering and guiding principle. Love must subordinate itself to justice (which according to Leibnitz is caritas sapientis, *the wise man's* love), as the guiding, distributing and harmonizing principle in human society.

Adam Smith has made an interesting attempt to show how the influence of sympathy leads to the formation of an ethical standard. Since we immediately feel pleasure or pain *[40]* at the actions of others, even if they do not concern us, we also come to express our approval or disapproval of them. We suffer with the victim of a cruel or faithless action and feel antipathy toward the one who commits such an action. On this sympathy and antipathy rests our approval and disapproval, which thus arises quite instinctively, as we involuntarily put ourselves in the place of the others, of the agent and of the sufferer. We play the part of spectators who feel with the persons appearing in the drama. Our first moral judgments we thus pass on others. Yet there comes a point in time when

we see that we ourselves are acting persons in the drama of life just as much as the others, for which reason we must assume that others judge us no less than we judge them. And sympathy itself, which seeks to even out the difference between our own state of feeling and that of others, since every disharmony here is bound up with a painful feeling, will lead us to examine our nature and our actions in order to see with what eyes we can expect others to regard us. We thus again put ourselves in the place of others, no longer merely in order to rejoice or suffer with them, but in order to view and evaluate ourselves from their standpoint. Everyone thus divides himself into two persons, a judging spectator and an acting being. The natural standpoint is abandoned; the individual looks away from himself precisely in order to come to know himself. It is
*[41]* a fact of experience that he who in the presence of others falls into passionate agitation involuntarily tones it down when he feels that the others, as impartial spectators, do not share it. On this rests the educating element in living together with others. Everyone feels himself the object of a constant and attentive criticism and involuntarily arranges his action so that he can stand before its tribunal. The child, the youth and the man thus learn in the various circumstances of life to look away from the individual standpoint. At last the inner spectator and judge in our breast no longer needs to be strengthened by the presence of outer spectators; we have gone through the great school of self-command and have our rule, our model, within ourselves. We now also look away from the finite and empirical standard that is given in the opinions and feelings of our surroundings, and turn our gaze toward an ideal of perfection that has gradually formed itself in our mind. The outer spectator thus first becomes an inner spectator, and this in turn an ideal model.

When development has reached this point, the original starting point, according to Adam Smith, passes wholly into the shade. Both the sympathetic and the egoistic impulses step aside for a higher feeling. "Since we are always affected far more strongly by what concerns ourselves than by what concerns others, what is it, then, that on every occasion brings the noble man, and sometimes even the base character, to sacrifice their own interests to the greater interests of others? It is not the mild power of love of
*[42]* humanity, not the feeble spark of benevolence that nature has kindled in the heart of man, that is thus able to counteract the strongest impulses of self-love. It is a stronger power, a more forceful motive, that acts on such occasions. It is reason, thought, conscience, the inner man who dwells in our breast, the great judge and arbiter of all our conduct. It is this that, whenever we are about to act in such a way that we hinder the happiness of others, calls out to us, with a voice that can drown out our most clamorous passions,

that we are only one of many, in no respect better than anyone else, and that when we so brazenly and blindly prefer ourselves to others, we rightly become the object of indignation, abhorrence and execration. From it we learn our real littleness and the littleness of everything that concerns us, and only through the eye of this impartial spectator can the natural illusions of self-love be corrected. It shows us the beauty of magnanimity and the ugliness of injustice, the rightness of giving up our own highest interests for the still higher interests of others, and the ugliness of inflicting on others the least injustice in order to obtain the greatest advantage for ourselves. It is not love of our neighbor or of the human race that on so many occasions spurs us to practice these divine virtues. It is a stronger love, a mightier feeling, that generally expresses itself on such occasions: the love of what is noble and honorable, of the greatness, dignity and loftiness of our character."[*)]

By this account Adam Smith has acknowledged that the sympathetic impulse in *[43]* itself is only one element contributing to the formation of the ethical law, but does not contain the full explanation of it, and in particular does not fully express the feeling, the disposition, that the ethical model awakens. One will also easily see that sympathy is too weak and too narrow an expression for the relation to the educating powers in the history of man and of the race. Sympathy presupposes a relation between equals, but the educating power stands, at least originally, as a superior. To that extent Hobbes and Bentham are more in the right when they point to fear and hope as the feelings that stir in the face of the authorities. However, this consideration we must hold back until we come to the special investigation of the concept of authority. On the other hand, Smith's doctrine of "the impartial spectator" invites us to investigate the significance of cognition, of reason, in an ethical respect. It plays, as we have seen, a great part both in the morality of utility and in the morality of sympathy, but in both as a subordinate principle. In order to grasp its significance better, we now turn to the attempts that have been made to make it itself the foundation of the ethical.

3. Both the morality of utility and the morality of sympathy concede that the immediate impulses cannot be called ethical, but that there is first a question of ethical action when a consciousness has formed of a law and rule that points beyond the moment's immediate promptings. Such a consciousness presupposes cognition, reason, thinking. *[44]* Therefore it is only in the human world that the ethical is at home; the degree of development of conscious life that it presupposes is not yet found in the animal world, and has surely also been attained by men only after the lapse of long ages. It was long

[*)] Theory of moral sentiments. Vol. 1. part. 3. chap. 3.

before human life began to be guided by thoughts, and we have not yet got beyond the beginning. — When we here set thought or reason, as an ethical starting point, alongside the impulse of self-preservation and sympathy, we no longer conceive it as servant, but as master, and proceed from the fact that conscious cognition can, under certain conditions, determine man's action. The question is then whether this is an exhaustive explanation of the ethical.

But here we are stopped at once by a misgiving. According to our general psychological considerations, cognition in itself cannot set the will in motion. Thought becomes a motive only by calling forth feeling and impulse. Because I have quite distinctly and clearly seen something, it does not follow that I act accordingly; I do so only when the insight awakens living feeling and desire in me. There will certainly be a tendency to bring about harmony among the various elements of conscious life, but this tendency can in itself be just as instinctive as the impulse toward happiness and sympathy. If we imagine a clearly and many-sidedly developed reason, in accordance with which the will
*[45]* immediately acts, such a phenomenon will nevertheless not be referred to the ethical. The ethical turns out here again to presuppose a distance, because it sets a task that is to be solved, a distance that is filled out by the idea of a law whose validity man recognizes. It will therefore also turn out that when reason is set up as an ethical principle, it is really not reason in and for itself that is meant, but reason as the expression of man's true nature, so that the demand is that the nobility and dignity of human nature be given its due.

The general theme of this standpoint has been stated by *Pascal* in a famous utterance. "Man is the weakest reed in nature, but he is a thinking reed; the universe need not arm itself to crush him; a little smoke, a drop of water is enough to make an end of him. But even if the universe crushes him, he is still nobler than his murderer, because he knows that he dies, while the universe itself does not know the power it has over him. All our dignity, then, consists in thought. In thought we must place our pride, not in time or in space, which we cannot fill. Let us then labor to think rightly; that is the principle of morality." What Pascal expresses here is the enthusiasm at belonging to the world of spirit. Thought gives man a dignity that unconscious beings do not have.

Already in *Socrates* we find this principle. He taught that virtue is knowledge, because
*[46]* only that action is right which springs from real insight. Above all, everything depends on knowing oneself; for only he who knows his own capacities, powers and impulses can conduct himself in the right way in life. The more detailed grounding that Socrates gives of this goes in the direction of the doctrine of utility, and Stuart Mill has accordingly

been able to claim him for it. Socrates, namely, impresses the importance of right self-knowledge by pointing to the unfortunate consequences of ignorance and delusion. But even through the most prosaic rendering of Socrates' teaching it nevertheless emerges that he really laid the weight on another point. He maintained that "nothing was stronger than insight," that it was "something beautiful, which is able to rule over man, strong enough to help him through life." He who does not let himself be guided by cognition, but by blind desires and impulses, is slavish or bestial. A slave is he who has no share in the beautiful and good. "Does it not seem shameful to you," he says to Aristippus, "that a human being should behave like the most irrational animals, which are driven by sensual desire for the bait and blindly walk into the trap?" In his defense speech he likewise points to thought and its power as the expression of man's true nature, the cultivation of which must lie closer to his heart than the care for the bodily and for external goods. "My friend," so he addresses his fellow countryman, "you who are an Athenian, a citizen of a great city, the most famous of all for culture and strength, are you not ashamed to care only for amassing wealth and acquiring honor, while you do not concern yourself *[47]* about truth and wisdom, about your soul and its education!"

Already here, in the very founder of ethics, we thus see that when reason is set up as an ethical principle, what is really meant by it is the inner freedom and harmony in man's nature, which is possible only when his action is in accordance with his highest cognition. Man is then not drawn to different sides by conflicting desires and impulses; nor is he led blindly by the impressions from the surrounding world; unity, coherence and independence come into his nature. He becomes a little world for himself, independent in relation to the external world, and encloses within himself a harmonious fullness.

What Socrates had indicated in all simplicity remained the main thought in Greek ethics. Plato, Aristotle and the Stoics each in his own way conceived man's ethical action as consisting in his acting according to the highest law of his nature, with rational insight ruling. They find freedom in accordance with right insight, and in this freedom true humanity. Precisely this immediate conviction of the dominion of thought, which brought Socrates to reject with indignation the assumption that "anything could be stronger than insight," constituted the one-sidedness of Greek ethics. It overlooked the manifold conditionedness and limitedness of human spiritual life, and all the oppositions and contradictions, struggles and defeats, that follow from it. For it, the will fused partly with cognition, partly with immediate impulse. *[48]*

In modern times Kant again brought forward the idea of inner freedom, pointing to the law of reason as that which unconditionally obligates man. He showed clearly that

the law the ethical presupposes cannot be one immediately given in nature, but must be owed to another source than that from which man's involuntary actions spring. The ethical law, according to Kant, cannot be grounded — neither psychologically, physically nor theologically grounded. It points beyond everything given, beyond all experience and reality, in that it prescribes what ought to happen. Only in reason do we have such a power pointing beyond all experience. Reason's unconditional and ungroundable command stands as a fact for consciousness, an immediate demand to which man must bow. It would lose the character of an unconditional command (categorical imperative) if it were supported in any other way than by reason's immediate demand.

The progress from Socrates to Kant is easily seen. Socrates is still able to ground the value of insight only by pointing to its external utility; this grounding stands, with him, side by side with the appeal to man's dignity as a free rational being. Moreover, the thought of an opposition, a duality within man's nature, is foreign to Socrates. With right insight everything is given; thought does not appear as law, because an immediate
*[49]* harmony is presupposed between it and the other mental elements. Kant, on the other hand, raises reason as ethical principle above everything immediately given, and rejects every empirical grounding. And he determines reason as legislative, whereby a distance is presupposed between guiding and obeying elements in man's nature.

One would not be wholly wrong in deriving this opposition between Socrates and Kant from the great religious movement that lies between these two greatest figures in the history of humane ethics. Christianity set up an ideal fetched from a supernatural world, exalted above everything that human thought should be able to reach by its own powers. Do we not seem to hear an echo of this when, according to Kant's doctrine, the law of reason disdains all grounding fetched from reality? Christianity declared human nature sinful and corrupt. Are we not reminded of this by Kant's presupposition of the distance between the command of reason and man's actual action?

Yet the complete explanation will not thereby have been given. However profoundly that religious movement has acted upon European spiritual life, one must nevertheless not overlook that it is itself only one of the forms of the general opposition between antiquity and modern times. For the Greek, life stood as immediately given and complete. History did not yet tell him distinctly and urgently of great conflicts between different stages of human development; he did not have the conception of life as a struggle for
*[50]* existence and advancement that modern times have won through their experiences, their action and research. When life, instead of standing before the mind as a work of art in a limited frame, turns out to be movement and development, the mind must turn with

a quite different energy forward toward what is not yet but is to be. The thought of a task now becomes quite differently alive. Thought hastens ahead, anticipates the new stage of life in an ideal way, and passes judgment on the earlier stage. The ideal view that thus forms itself does not have its full explanation in the immediately given and present. We are here directed to the original energy of conscious life, by which even the simplest sense-sensation becomes more than a passive receiving, and by which every freer relation to the content of sensation and experience, and every working-up of it, becomes possible. It is this energy that makes it possible to form complete and finished images, ideals, out of the always incomplete elements in the actual world. Here is the source of all poetry and art, of all higher ideas. If one will call this capacity in man to form ideal ideas reason, then it is entirely correct that only through reason, as that which goes beyond the given, does the ethical law become possible, and that this law always stands exalted above actual action as a model which the latter strives to approach.

But when we take reason and law of reason in this sense, we cannot, like Kant, stop at reason's command as a mere fact; we must investigate how the idea of such a law has *[51]* developed psychologically and historically. This task we cannot evade without violating the simplest rules of scientific inquiry. The "facts" in the spiritual and ethical domain must be subjected to examination and grounding just as much as all other facts. We must here invoke the critical Kant against the dogmatic Kant; and he himself comes to meet us here by his account of how the law of reason determines man's action. Only through feeling, as we know, can reason awaken the will. The law of reason stands, by its unconditional authority, as a power exalted above the individual. The sensuous impulses are pushed back, the immediate feeling of life and self-confidence are checked and humbled by the thought of this unconditional law. Man feels before the law within him, just as before the clear starry heavens, his littleness, at the same time as he is filled with admiration and reverence; for the ethical law acts repellingly on the sensuous and egoistic impulse only in order to exert so much the greater attraction on man's proper self, which feels itself one with the law. In the law we therefore find an expression of our true will. But whatever one may think of reason, — a feeling such as admiration and reverence must, after all, have its natural history, and we have not rightly understood the ethical until we have explored it.

Since Kant regards the ethical law of reason as raised above all experience, everything *[52]* given and present, he cannot give it any definite content. But it lies in the very concept of a law that it is universally valid, does not adjust and accommodate itself to the single individual, but is common to him and all others. The general content of the ethical law

is then: Everyone shall act in such a way that the principle he follows in his action can serve as a general rule for all. Man shall regard each of his actions as a link in a higher natural connection, which is to be realized through his striving. — This principle Kant himself regards as purely formal and independent of experience, and his critics as a rule grant him this, only that they consider it a fault, he a virtue. But whence, one must ask, does pure reason get the idea of a universal legislation, if not through experience? In actual life we see the single human being as a link in society, in the race; we see definite, factual laws holding for the life of men together, and we then form, by abstraction and idealization, the idea of a perfect society where each individual fits himself in with full regard to all others, so that one and the same law holds for all. In the ethical principle Kant sets up we can therefore see nothing purely a priori, but a historical idea brought back to ideal simplicity. As we have seen earlier (above S. 4—5), it lies in the nature of our cognition to operate with ideal concepts, but these are applied in ethics in a different
*[53]* way than in natural science. In the domain of nature we regard the ideal concepts as approximations to the actual connection, but in the ethical domain the actual as an approximation to the imagined ideal. Experience always lies at the base; only from it can the elements for the ideal constructions be fetched.

When we see the matter in this way, we also have points of attachment for the ideas of the doctrine of utility and of the doctrine of sympathy. Culture, regarded as resting on a system of interests that mutually support one another, gets its place in the idea of the ideal society as its real foundation. Without having its firm ground in the primitive demands of life, the ideal society hovers in the air. Against every ascetic way of looking at things it is also of importance to assert the individual's right to self-satisfaction. What utilitarianism overlooks is that this right, ethically seen, must have its ground precisely in the individual's dignity as a member of the realm of human personalities, just as every juridical right, after all, points back to society and its law as its foundation. The doctrine of sympathy has had a deeper understanding of the individual's inner relation to the race; and it rightly emphasizes benevolence and love of humanity as the living bond that holds society together and makes it more than a mechanically joined heap of atoms; but since our recognition of the law is a main element in ethical action, we cannot stop at instinctive feelings. Sympathy as well as individual interest must be subordinated to
*[54]* the highest understanding we are able to gain of the fundamental law, end and tasks of human life. The realization of the kingdom of humanity must stand as the end and fundamental law of our action.

But here it has once again turned out that we cannot understand the ethical as long

as we stop at the consideration of the single individual. Here too we are directed back to the great connection in which the individual arises and develops, and to which he owes what he is and has. Whether we proceed from reason, from sympathy or from the impulse toward happiness, we are of necessity led out beyond the domain of individuality. From the maternal womb of society the single individualities spring, and it is, on the other hand, as representatives of and co-workers on the ideal society of harmonious personalities that they reach the highest development. We must therefore begin a new investigation of our question, such that we no longer proceed from the single individual but from the higher power that from the outset encloses all individuals.

## Authority.

*[55]* The more intricate and complex a subject is, the more necessary it is to employ the descriptive method. As long as we kept to the single individual and the general psychological laws that determine its action, the relations were easy to survey and to analyze; but indispensable as the individual starting points are, it has nevertheless turned out that the analysis brought to light essential elements which find their explanation only when we take a social starting point. The single individual we could in the main regard as a fixed type; society, on the other hand, and in general the powers under whose shelter the individual comes into being and develops, belong to the rich and manifold world of history, where everything is subject to movement and development. Ethics here points back to history. It has not been the least cause of the imperfection of ethics that the great significance of history as its foundation has not been heeded. In particular,
*[56]* the eighteenth century, whose sons the greatest modern ethicists (Ad. Smith, Bentham and Kant) were, could not, because of its whole abstract and individualistic tendency, duly appreciate this significance. It is only our century, whose open historical sense has also led to the conviction of the importance of the historical foundation for ethics. Schleiermacher and Hegel, Comte and Spencer show themselves, each in his own way, imbued with this conviction.

It has turned out in the preceding that one cannot determine the nature of ethical action except by referring to the idea of a law; but the concept of law we take originally from human society. It goes in the ethical domain as in the spiritual domain in general: we use expressions and ideas that are taken from the outer world in order to make clear to ourselves the nature and coherence of the inner world. Obligation, too, is properly a juridical expression. Both law and obligation presuppose an authority that not merely commands but upholds the carrying out of the command. Without power no law and no obligation. But power alone would call forth only fear. It is only the last resort (ultima ratio) for upholding the law. The authority on which the law rests appeals to other elements in man's nature than fear. The deterrent plays its greatest part at the lowest stages of development, where the law is essentially a fence against danger and ruin. According to the old myth, the first law that went out to man was the prohibition against
*[57]* eating of the fruit of a certain tree, since it would bring death. The child first learns to know the law when it is to be brought up to cleanliness, and here the averting and the

deterring play the greatest part. The law acquires a more positive significance when the authority stands not merely as a threatening power, but through its whole superiority comes to stand as a guiding model for man. When man sees, in the authority to which he is subject, capacities and powers that far surpass those he feels in himself, he feels sympathy with it, and the impulse to imitate is awakened. Already among the animals the swiftest and strongest becomes the leader of the herd. As soon as intelligence is tolerably developed, admiration is awakened for everything great, new and striking; and with it reverence and respect combine in turn, the more man, through his increased experiences, feels his littleness and powerlessness, the more, that is, his self-esteem is lowered by the contemplation of the model's superiority. The benefits he receives from the higher power awaken gratitude, and at last he ties his whole weal and woe to it with free trust and devotion. Over against mere power man will always be able to think of resistance, until he is utterly overwhelmed and paralyzed by fear; but when the feeling of dependence is purified by being combined with the feelings of sympathy, of the impulse to imitate, of admiration, of reverence and of gratitude, and thereby develops into recognition and self-surrender, we have the essence of obligation in the ethical *[58]* sense. The center of gravity begins to shift from the outer to the inner.

This relation to an obligating authority can be traced through the whole course of mankind's development under different forms. An absolute state of nature without authorities does not exist. Already Hobbes remarks, as we have cited earlier, that no one is born in the state of nature. Wholly without authority would be only such beings as grew up out of the earth, as in the myths of the ancients, or, according to the Homeric expression, were the offspring of a stone or a tree; and only they could be complete individualists. The authority of the family is thus the most primitive. At the lowest stages at which human beings are found living (according to various recent travelers as well as to Herodotus's account of several savage nations), the family admittedly does not yet exist as a closed group; and the mother takes care of the child only as long as it is wholly helpless; but already through the protection and the benefits that here fall to the child's share, and without which it could not live, the ground is laid for a relation of piety which can become the germ of further development. When the roving life is replaced by more fixed and regular conditions, family life comes to play a greater part. The father's authority now replaces the mother's. At this stage marriage is grounded on power, not on love; wife, children and slaves must bow in equal degree to the will of the head of the family.[*)] The protection the weak enjoy, and the constant living together, *[59]*

[*)] *Lubbock*: Origin of civilisation.

in part also working together, call forth other feelings too besides fear, but this feeling nevertheless always lies at the bottom. The unconditional authority of the head of the family within his circle maintained itself even after the family had become part of a more comprehensive society. In ancient Rome the power of the father of the family and of the husband was subject to no restrictions whatever; he was answerable to no one on earth. How profound an influence the relation to this authority must have exercised on the ways of thinking and acting of the growing generations will easily be seen; and however changed these relations may be in modern societies, most people still have within the family the first objects of fear and love, admiration and gratitude, respect and reverence. It is under the influence of these living forces that the circle of ideas is formed and the first rules for action, the first moral laws, arise. The individual here has his practical world-view grounded, and the validity of this world-view he feels as one with the very authority from which it stems. Violation or contradiction of it is felt so strongly because it strikes the very innermost and deepest feeling in the individual.

The bond of blood is the first that unites human beings and thereby creates an authority. For long ages it has been the only one, or in any case the mightiest; but
*[60]* the family points beyond itself, in that the head of one family stands independent over against that of the other. Through the fusion of the individual families and clans a civil society arises. An absolute boundary between the two kinds of society can, historically regarded, be difficult to draw, since the head of the family earlier had, after all, much of the authority that the head of state later acquired. In the Roman state one can trace the original union of the individual clans. "The Roman state," says Mommsen,[*)] "rests on the Roman house, with respect to its elements as well as with respect to its form. The people arose as the old clans in one way or another joined together; the Roman territory arose from the united districts of these clans; a Roman citizen was he who belonged to one of these clans." The bond of blood here plainly lies at the bottom. Such a primitive society can grow only by adoption; even the relation of friendship first acquires its significance among many savage and barbarian peoples when the friends have mingled blood and thus, at least symbolically, brought about a natural bond.[**)] Anyone who was not tied to the tribe by this bond was an enemy or a slave. Since the heads of the individual clans stand as equals, there will be no permanent head for the whole horde. Just as the cohesion in general is still so weak that the horde scatters and each looks
*[61]* after himself when distress is at hand, so too one has a leader only as long as one needs him. Yet the old and the wise, the strong and the brave will stand in greater esteem than

[*)] Römische Geschichte. I. S. 59.

[**)] Cf. *Maine*: Early history of institutions. S. 228.

the others. And the more the struggle with other tribes makes cohesion necessary, the more will authority also be consolidated. War therefore seems, as Bagehot in particular has emphasized, to have worked as a binding means within the tribe. The leaders in battle were regarded as the protectors of all. Under very simple conditions of culture no great outward distance can arise between those who command and those who obey; therefore we first get a properly political authority when inequality in the distribution of property removes the rulers from those who obey them, and when at the same time society becomes large enough for the ruler to be withdrawn from the constant gaze of individuals. The ruler now becomes an object of reverence; envy is excluded by the very greatness of the distance. His will is unconditional law.[*)] Although habit and instinct, convention and custom form a kind of fundamental law which even the despot cannot or will not break, it is nevertheless a sign of progress when a personal, conscious will asserts itself; only thereby does law in the sense of a general, impartial and inflexible rule become possible.[**)] And this is a progress not merely in a purely cultural-historical but also in an ethical respect, insofar as blind habit is replaced by conscious submission.

Power, the protecting and the commanding power, is the first foundation of political *[62]* authority, just as of authority within the family. Supported on this foundation, the higher and freer forms of social life can develop. One often imagines the life of savages as free and unbound; but on the contrary it is led under a heavy pressure of authority. "They are governed," says Lubbock, "by rules and conventions that form one of the cruelest tyrannies that has perhaps ever existed on the face of the earth. The will of the weak, their property, their life are subject to the dominion of the stronger. The tendency of the whole system is to give everything to the strong and the old to the detriment of the young and the weak, but especially of the women."[*)] When this heavy pressure is taken away, the most complete anarchy, the wildest licentiousness, often sets in, as among some Negro tribes, where everything is in dissolution at the death of the chieftain. It is a severe school that the human race must go through at this stage, but it has been necessary. And even the most despotic state authority must nevertheless have awakened other feelings than fear; for it appears not merely as commanding but also as protecting, affords a shelter under which life can go its way. The privileges that the ruler assumed were in reality bought with services. A great example of this we have in the institutions of the Middle Ages, the foundation of "l'ancien régime". The king, the nobility and the

[*)] Cf. *Adam Ferguson*: An essay on the history of the civil society. Part II. Sect. 3, and *Herodotus's* story of Deioces (Herod. I. 96).

[**)] *Maine*: Early history. S. 392.

[*)] Origin of civilisation, S. 434.

*[63]* clergy have in rude and savage times, through their physical and spiritual authority, made human life and human development possible.[*)] In the trust and the gratitude that the protecting power awakens lies the germ of the ethical character of authority, which is originally pushed back as long as fear and instinctive custom reign.

We have brought forward some basic features of the oldest history of authority, as it is accessible to us especially through the comparative study of primitive forms of society in recent years. Here the relations are simplest and easiest to survey; at later stages of development so many different elements play a part that it is attended with difficulty to consider each of them by itself. Just as the study of the fetal state affords the physiologist valuable contributions to the understanding of the completed organism and its conditions of life, so the study of those simple and primitive forms of life is also of importance for the psychologist, the ethicist and the sociologist.[**)] They are like
*[64]* experiments that nature and history have made for us in a domain where we cannot experiment; and yet in the preceding we have made the relations still simpler than they are in reality; for as soon as man has raised himself to the real beginning of a social life, he feels himself related not merely to the authorities that rule in family, tribe and state, but to a still higher authority, which lies beyond the bounds of these societies, and in which at last those authorities themselves seek their support: the religious authority. Only through this last support can the principle of authority become absolute. As one of this principle's most consistent defenders, Bonald, has said: "Religion, which is the general bond in every society, tightens preeminently the knot of political society; the very word religion (religare) indicates sufficiently that it is the natural and necessary bond of human societies, families and states. — Religion brings order into society, because it teaches men whence power and duties stem. — All power is created in God's image and stems from God."[*)]

If one regards as the essential thing in religion the feeling of dependence on a higher order of things, one must in reality grant that those are right who maintain that there are peoples without religion. Such a feeling always presupposes a certain spiritual development, which is not found among human beings who lack the capacity to form
*[65]* general ideas, or who have not yet thought about whether the sun that rises in the morning is the same one that sets in the evening.[*)] If on the other hand one demands

[*)] Cf. H. *Taine*: L'ancien régime. Livre I. Chap. 1.: Origine des priviléges.

[**)] We have in our own literature a work on this subject from the beginning of this century by C. *Bastholm* (Historiske Efterretninger til Kundskab om Mennesket i dets vilde og raa Tilstand. 4 vols. Copenhagen 1803—4). Under the title of "Descriptive Sociology" *Herbert Spencer* with several collaborators has begun to publish tabular surveys of the cultural-historical conditions of the various peoples.

[*)] G. *Brandes*: Reaktionen i Frankrig. S. 110; 118 f.

[*)] *Lubbock*: Origin of civilisation, p. 10; 475. (The languages of many savage peoples have names for

of religion only belief in spiritual beings,[**)] then one cannot deny that it is found in the crudest fetish-worshipper, who does not even harbor fear of his fetish but merely regards it as a necessary means and tool. A trace of a moral relation shows itself already within fetishism, in that the Negro veils the fetish (as the Russian peasant does his saint) when he does something he is ashamed of. Even where greater and mightier beings are worshipped, fear is long the ruling feeling: one worships only the evil beings; the good beings, one thinks, need no attention, since it is their nature to be good. This dualism between good and evil beings is therefore not of an ethical nature either, but springs from the utility or harm that man has experienced. Thus the sun is in cold countries a good being, in hot countries an evil being. It is anything but friendly feelings that men at this stage harbor toward the gods they worship.

Only in idolatry proper, where anthropomorphism has made its way through, does religion become real submission. Ethical ideas are transferred from political society, where their first development has taken place, to the world of the gods. The human race *[66]* seems to have reached the standpoint of monarchy in politics before it reached that of idolatry in religion. The deities now gradually change from mere powers of nature into ethical powers, a transition that can be followed especially within Greek mythology. And just as the belief in gods changes, so too does the belief in immortality; men now no longer believe merely in a continuation of existence indifferent in itself, but in a retribution after death. The standard of this retribution is given with what the people commend as virtues or vices.[*)]

It marks a higher stage when the good, too, is recognized and worshipped. With gratitude is combined admiration of the great and the exalted. The Fijians' word for God (kalon) means in general whatever is great and wonderful; it is a superlative expression. And at the highest stage of folk religion that we know, the religious idea raises its object wholly above nature, in that everything in the world is seen as brought forth by the will of the deity. The feeling of dependence first becomes complete here, in that man stands, over against omnipotence, as absolutely powerless. What the omnipotent divine will commands is the highest law. A firmer and deeper foundation for the ethical law seems not to be findable. Here authority has reached its highest form, appears as absolute, *[67]* unconditional. Authority in family and state is only derived in relation to it. And although the divine authority has for the believer clothed itself in the attributes of wisdom, love and justice, so that he worships in it not merely the infinite power but also the ideal

each particular color, each particular kind of tree, but none to denote color or tree in general).

[**)] *Tylor*: Primitive culture. I. p. 382.

[*)] Cf. *Tylor's* and *Lubbock's* above-mentioned works and *Preller's* "Griechische Mythologie".

of holiness, it is nevertheless the omnipotence of the will, and the fear and trembling that the idea of it must awaken, that is the ultimate foundation. The older theologians state this without reserve. It is the desire for eternal blessedness that leads man to God; "men," says Augustine, "ought to worship no god unless he can make them blessed; if blessedness were a goddess, she would be the only one who ought to be worshipped." Obedience to God's will is therefore, as Augustine likewise shows, the fundamental Christian virtue.*) The consistent carrying through of this standpoint therefore cannot give up the doctrine of the punishments of hell, for without them authority would be weakened. They are the keystone of the edifice of absolute authority. —

These features of the history of authority were meant only to illustrate, to some extent, a principle that has intervened very mightily in the ethical development of the human race. There was a time when, in revolutionary zeal, one had eyes only for the less fortunate aspects of the principle of authority and could not name it except in order to declaim against it. Now most, to be sure, agree about its great historical mission, which
*[68]* is not yet ended, and one is perhaps often inclined, out of counter-revolutionary zeal, to regard its cultural-historical significance as a proof of its truth in principle. The conduct of many modern apologists recalls, as *Vacherot* has aptly said, Scipio Africanus, who answered the charge of embezzlement with the words: "Let us go to the Capitol and thank the gods because I beat Hannibal at Zama!" The crowd followed him, but the accounts were hardly the more correct for that. We cannot avoid settling the accounts. We were led to authority as to the historical power that originally awakened the idea of a higher law in man's breast, and on which this law has hitherto rested. Just as necessary as it was for us to bring forward the concept of authority, just so necessary is it now to examine whether it is necessarily bound up with the concept of law, and which of these two concepts is, ethically regarded, the essential one. Since it is a question of principle, we must take up authority in its completed, its unconditional form, and this we have, as shown, in the religious authority. The question of principle that we raise is the old point of contention between theological and philosophical, Christian and humane ethics.

The law presupposes an authority to which man bows. But with this it is not yet given that the authority itself is one with the law. If I bow to the law because it is the expression of the authority's will, then my motives have not sprung from the idea of
*[69]* the law itself and its content, but must be sought in the relation in which I, apart from the law, stand to the one who commands, be this relation now one of fear, of piety or of reverence. Thus it is only by a detour that I arrive at recognition of the law. If it were

*)De civitate dei. lib. V. præf. — XIV. c. 12.

another who uttered it, I would perhaps not obey it; but I would also obey a contrary command if it went out from the same authority. The content of the law thus becomes something accidental, and man is caught in the contradiction that his most energetic action, that into which he puts everything, stands in a purely arbitrary relation to his own nature. A third power always thrusts itself in between him and that for which he works, and an unconditional power at that, before which everything else becomes nothing. The unconditional authority is a "jealous God," who tolerates nothing beside himself. And even if the authority is not absolute, — when it cannot make itself one with the content of the law, it steps disturbingly in between man and his task, hinders the direct, inward relation.

In the (original, consistent) Christian ethics this comes clearly to light. It is said in general that the commandment of love is the chief law of Christian ethics. In this commandment, great and exalted as it is, there lies in itself nothing that points beyond the humane. To love others, apart from all differences, and to love them unconditionally, is a commandment that Buddha had already uttered. The Stoic philosophers had likewise earlier set up love for the whole human race (caritas generis humani) as the fundamental *[70]* ethical law, although they were not able to procure for it so deep and inward a recognition, even among the simple, as the Gospel, which precisely thereby proved its historical mission. Here, where we have to do only with principles, we must disregard the practical significance they may have under certain historical conditions. It then turns out on closer consideration that it is not for men's own sake that we are to love them, but for God's sake. Love is not the fundamental Christian virtue, but obedience, submission to the divine will. Without this, Christianity would not be a positive religion. Positive religion means religion grounded on authority, and obedience is the fundamental relation toward authority. In Christianity this finds its more precise expression in love's being subordinated to faith. The apostle Paul indeed teaches that love is greater than faith, but Christianity recognizes only the love that is grounded on faith, faith in the supernatural authority. Therefore the virtues of the heathen are, in the eyes of earnest Christians, only splendid vices. In its commandment of love Christianity, like Buddha and the Stoics before it, pointed beyond the outward differences that divided the ancient world: there shall no longer be any difference between Greek and barbarian, between bond and free; but it has itself, in return, established an opposition that is surely as strong as any of those: that between believers and unbelievers, the blessed and the Damned. Faith and *[71]* love therefore work against each other,[*)] and the commandment of love first comes

[*)] See *Ludwig Feuerbach*: Wesen des Christenthums (Cf. my book "Filosofien i Tyskland efter Hegel" p. 65—67).

into its full right when one goes beyond the bounds of faith. But this Christianity, as a *positive* religion, cannot do. Therefore the commandment of love has first attained its completion in the modern principle of toleration, which treats the differences of faith in the same way as Christianity treated the outward and national differences. Spinoza is the first who has drawn the consequences of the commandment of love and carried through in practice the proposition that love is greater than faith. The humane element in Christianity has hereby been freed from the bounds that hampered it.

It is not only love that acquires a merely indirect significance under the presupposition of the principle of authority; the same holds of every humane and cultural-historical relation. Marriage, on the strict Christian view, can only become the lesser of two evils. Paul advises the slave against seeking to obtain freedom, and Luther says in his blunt language: "Serfdom is not contrary to the Christian essence, and whoever says so, he lies." Before the one infinite object that is to fill the minds of all believers, everything that has only human significance must be pushed aside.

*[72]* One will perhaps object that we here push the matter to an extreme and conceive authority as the purely arbitrary. "Certainly," one will say, "we accept the good as good only because it is God's will; but since the good is one with God's essence, he wills only what is good, and so what becomes the content of the law does not rest on arbitrariness and chance." But this is only to push the whole question further back, unless one ascribes to oneself so intimate an acquaintance with the essence of the Godhead that one knows the reasons that determine its will. And if one knows these reasons, one can see their correctness; why then take the detour of appealing to the supernatural will, instead of applying them directly? As soon as authority does not wholly subdue us by an unconditional command of power, it cannot avoid being called to account; but an account presupposes that there is something that stands above authority, and by which the latter can be judged.

Although *Martensen* in his "kristelige Ethik" energetically maintains the necessity of the supernatural, unconditional authority as the foundation of the ethical, he has nevertheless clearly seen that one must establish the justification of authority. He solves the question by saying: "The right of authority is grounded in the ethical, to which power is subordinate" (p. 449). This proposition we could subscribe to entirely. But what, then, does Martensen here understand by "the ethical"? If it is to be of the same nature as the ethical whose explanation we sought, then according to Martensen's teaching we must
*[73]* of course again seek a higher authority, whose will can give it validity — a power, then, that can obligate God! And if the proposition that the ethical presupposes an obligating

power standing above the one who is obligated is to hold only for the humanly ethical, not for the ethical in the essence of the Godhead, then this latter "ethical" becomes for us an empty word, a sign that one has applied the concept where it no longer has any validity, let alone that it can serve for any explanation whatsoever. Beyond this dilemma theological ethics cannot get.

Where authority is absolute, i.e., where it is raised above all grounding, it must make itself known by a miracle. For the theological conception, therefore, the connection of nature is broken at the point where the ethical begins. "The ethical 'Ought'," says Martensen, "remains in all eternity inexplicable from nature. It comes not from below, but from above" (p. 441). And later he maintains that the majestic: "Thou shalt!" does not even find its explanation in our ideal nature (p. 456). But for Martensen spiritual life as a whole is "a miracle for nature, a transcendent for the whole concept of nature" (p. 16). What we must object here is that theology constantly confuses the (as yet, or in itself) inexplicable with the miracle. The miracle is a fiat, an asylum of ignorance (asylum ignorantiæ), in which theology takes refuge in order to fill the holes it believes it has discovered in scientific knowledge. Humane ethics, which must apply the same scientific procedure that holds everywhere else in the world of thought and of nature, does not imagine that it can solve all riddles; it seeks to get as far as it can by the natural ways; *[74]* the rest it leaves undecided. But it cannot proceed from so narrow a concept of nature as theology does. Although consciousness cannot be derived from the unconscious life of nature, it can nevertheless be shown that, as regards the conditions of its origin and development, it stands in the closest connection with it and cannot be understood without this connection. The psychological and ethical laws are therefore laws of nature, just as spiritual life as a whole is a link in the infinite life of nature itself and emerges at a certain definite stage of development of the latter. To the popular conception it does of course appear as if certain spiritual states, thoughts and feelings had so exalted a character that they could not possibly be brought into connection with the ordinary psychological laws. Thus the motions of the heavenly bodies stood for the ancients as divine and ideal, so that it was a presumption to explain them in a natural way; and yet in modern times they have found their mechanical explanation. However far psychology and ethics lag behind astronomy, they nevertheless rest on the same principle; they too strive after a "mécanique céleste", a natural explanation of "the heavenly things" in the domain of spiritual life. Faith, worship and love will find their psychological and historical explanation, just as the more elementary phenomena of consciousness have already found theirs.

*[75]* It is the task of historical science to describe for us the origin and development of the authorities. These are to be regarded as natural beings, which unfold according to definite laws. Historical development and its laws stand above all authorities and comprise them all. When the conditions of an authority's validity are past, it gives way, as history shows, to another. History is the battleground of the authorities. But precisely in their fighting lies the fact that they are, after all, finite beings. They are like the gods of Olympus, who descended onto the battlefield and could be wounded by men.

Herein we find the possibility of recognizing the great significance of the authorities for the ethical and yet maintaining that the principle of authority in itself is not the full ground of the ethical. They are the educating powers in the history of the race. But he who educates another strives, of course, precisely to free him, to bring him to stand on his own feet and see with his own eyes. He strives to make himself superfluous, to disappear himself, so that the disciple can come face to face with the matter itself. This resignation is demanded of every educator, but the authorities in every domain forget it all too often. Precisely hereby they prove their finitude. For that whereby the authority differs from the law that is to be upheld, the end that is to be attained, is the egoism, the self-will, that it asserts at the expense of the cause that was to be furthered. With this it agrees well that authority always in the last instance comes to appeal to egoistic
*[76]* motives, above all to fear. Ethical validity it has only as the bearer of a content that can prove its justification quite apart from the authority, and only thereby does it become an object of admiration, reverence and love; if, on the other hand, it acts beyond the justification this content gives, it sinks back to its most primitive forms. As long as the authority stands as a third between the agent on the one side and the law and end of the action on the other, so long is action only indirectly ethical, because other motives rule than the very recognition of the law and reverence for it. Ethics thus reduces all authorities to being relative instead of absolute, means instead of ends. Authority exists for man's sake, not man for authority's. When the personality has developed so that the recognized law is his only, or at any rate his deepest, motive, then there is in him an authority before which all outward powers are nothing. The center of gravity is shifted from the outer to the inner, — the great goal of all education!

It is the task of modern times to transform the authorities from absolute to relative. Instead of the weight under which life groaned so long as a supernatural authority, partly immediately, partly through its representatives and servants, embraced everything, great and small, with its commandments and its prohibitions, modern times work to bring about a freer and higher development by making the heavy thing the foundation instead

of the roof and spire. For this the Reformation and the Revolution fought, each in its way. Authority is a condition of life for social life, and thereby also for the ethical life, *[77]* but life first reaches its higher development when authority subordinates itself. The conviction will make its way that the ethical ideas have their validity and their worth in themselves, through their intimate connection with the essence and conditions of human life, although historically they develop under the shelter of authority. By working to make the latter relative instead of absolute, one therefore works in the service of the ethical. For the consciousness of most people, to be sure, the ethical ideas have entered into so close a connection with the idea of the absolute authority that an attack on the latter also seems to them to be an attack on the ethical; hence the constant accusation against free inquiry that it leads to unethical consequences. Just as the pagans in Alexandria expected that heaven and earth would fall back into the old chaos when the Christians overthrew the statue of Serapis,[*)] so many now think that human life will, in ethical respects, dissolve into a chaos when the old dogmas are toppled from the place they have hitherto occupied as ruling powers. For him who has a freer view and a bolder faith the matter appears otherwise. Without fantastic illusions, and without being frightened by the passing excesses that never fail to appear where great and new ideas are breaking through, he will leave it to the quiet but sure course of historical *[78]* development to bring harmony between the practical forms of life and the new ideas. We have seen in an earlier connection of how essential importance it is for the individual human being to be in harmony with his own highest knowledge. The same must hold for society as a whole, for the whole race: if an idea is thus really grounded in human nature, it will also work its way forward to practical recognition, however little we may be able to survey all the intermediate stages, the ways and detours, that must first be traversed here. Here, then, *Pascal* is right when he says: "Let us work at thinking rightly; that is the principle of morality!" That is at least the contribution that theoretical ethics ought to make to the development of the ethical life.

Only those authorities, then, are ethically justified which see their own relative significance. The supernatural authority must always answer every call to subordinate itself in the same way as its most consistent representative, the Roman Church, answers the call to recognize the progress of history: "Impossible!" (Non possumus). The essence of the humane authorities, on the other hand, is not violated by such a call. Authority is here essentially an expression of tradition, which the one generation transmits to the next, giving it along on the way as an indispensable support, until it can stand on its

[*)] *Gibbon*: The decline and fall of the Roman Empire. Chap. 28.

own feet. Only thereby does continuity arise in the human race, and only thereby do progress and development become possible, that each new generation does not begin
*[79]* afresh, but stands on the shoulders of the preceding ones. The clash between the older and the younger generation rests partly on the inherited forms not always yielding after their proper role is played out, partly also on the unbridled and impatient eruption of the new forms. But the very hard struggles that can arise from this have their great significance: freedom must be won through struggle; the recognition of the inner, higher law cannot be grafted on from outside. The resistance that even the relative authorities are thus inclined to offer to their own subordination serves precisely for a more inward, freer and more vigorous development of the new forms. Yet it must always stand as an essential task to make this transition as short and as easy as possible, and this will become possible the more the conviction spreads that "the right of authority is grounded in the ethical": the more the authorities really act as educating powers, and the more inwardly and deeply their significance is therefore also recognized by all. The ethical law is not only to issue from authority, but also to be applied to it. An absolute authority is raised above all laws, even above those it has itself given; but the relative authorities one can measure by their own yardstick.

As a member of the race, each finds himself set to solve his particular task as it emerges from all the historical conditions. He is a child of the past and helps to create the future. He cannot see his dependence on what has gone before without at the same time seeing that what is to come is in part determined by his conduct. However limited
*[80]* his horizon and his sphere of activity may be, he is never excluded from regarding himself as a fellow worker in humanity's great society, advancing through the ages. The consciousness of this, under whatever form it may show itself, is one with the feeling of obligation, with the recognition of a higher law. Here we have the ethical in its simplest and purest form. *Comte* has beautifully and aptly shown how that consciousness arises within family life and constantly points back to it. Through the relation of piety toward the parents the child enters into relation with the past of the race and at once receives a deep impression of how closely its whole existence is bound up with it. In the relation of brothers, and later in the relation to fellow workers and contemporaries in general, the individual is led into the whole great circle of solidary interests, where he too is to contribute his mite. The connection does not stand out here so clearly as within the family, but the further culture advances, the more closely bound up all human endeavors nevertheless prove to be, so that progress in one direction is in the long run impossible without corresponding progress in other directions. The relation of father, finally, forms

the conclusion and points toward the future. What appears in its simplest form within the family can be extended and developed to comprise the whole race. There is one great circle of tasks that is essentially conditioned by the relation to the past; it comprises everything that serves to preserve and secure human life, and the organization, the fixed forms, without which life can here no more than anywhere else subsist. Another great *[81]* circle of tasks points toward the future; to it belongs everything whereby life can receive higher and wider development and enrichment. Order and progress presuppose each other: order is the condition of progress, and progress is the end of order.*) In both circles of tasks personal life finds its content and its nourishment. The harmonious society of free personalities, which in this connection too proves to be the highest ethical idea, is not a mere ideal, but is relatively and partly realized in every ethically developed personality. If the goal always lay in the future, ethical action would take on the character of a Tantalean chase after something that always eludes us. But the kingdom for whose coming we are to work has already come where the work is done rightly, whether the work in the particular case is concentrated chiefly on the development of the individual's own personal life in its various directions, or has a more outward-going character. The connection with the great and common end of the human race hallows and ennobles even the humblest deed, when it is performed with faithfulness.

It is not merely abstract laws and reflections that meet thought in the contemplation of the development of human life. The great figures of history, in whom the human tasks and ends appear as though personified, stand as models, as types of what human life *[82]* can be. Some of these figures have, even in the form in which they have been handed down to us, such a stamp of perfection that they seem raised above the struggles and difficulties through which it is the lot of most to work their way forward. Myth and legend have in many cases been inspired by the same thought that *Schiller* expresses in one of his epigrams, that noble natures count by what they *are*, lower natures by what they *do*. It is a thought that has its great justification, since, as was just remarked, the way and the goal, ethically considered, cannot fall entirely outside each other. But "the church militant" needs models who have *really* fought themselves, for whom the struggle has been more than a divine game. The model can therefore no more be absolute than authority can: that would be the same as making it useless for relative beings. What we are to learn from it is precisely what human life can be made into by the exertion of man's own powers.

Life of great men all remind us,

*)Politique positive I. 95; 105.

We can make our life sublime. (Longfellow.)

However mighty an influence the thought of progressing humanity may have, especially when it is seen represented in the outstanding personalities, the consideration of the ethical nevertheless leads us further. Development did not first begin with the
*[83]* appearance of man. The best-grounded hypotheses[*)] lead us to see the origin of the human race itself as the result of a long organic and physical process of development. Through a series of stages, under the most diverse forms, the life of nature rises from the dim nebular masses to the highest spiritual clarity. Everywhere we can find the same fundamental laws, the progressive formation of smaller wholes within the larger whole.[**)] Every individual form, in the organic as in the inorganic, in the human as in the animal world, marks a peculiar stage in the great development of life. We do not explain the higher from the lower because we see the former emerge from the latter; on the contrary, we first rightly understand the life of the world when we see what it is able to achieve at its summits, in its most individual forms. Man, precisely according to the hypothesis of evolution, is no stranger in the world, but has his roots deep in its innermost essence; and what stands for man as necessary, as true and as good, is just as much a reality as the outward, material masses. By working for the realization of his ideals, by developing and perfecting human life, he plays the role that is to be played at the place where he is set. He stands as the final end of a long development, and his
*[84]* natural task is to fill this place in such a way that he not only maintains it, but also uses it to carry the development further. His struggle for existence becomes a struggle for the dignity of man. It is the spiritual life, the life of thought, of feeling and of will, whereby man distinguishes himself from the lower stages of life, and which he must guard and develop if he does not want to sink back from the place he has won. All the individual starting points that we have brought forward earlier now acquire their proper significance by being fitted into the great connection in which human life stands. The *impulse of self-preservation*, which by concentrating one-sidedly on the single individual becomes egoism, acquires its justification when it is seen that the individual's struggle to subsist is a condition of the subsistence and development of the whole race. The tasks that set the individual interests in motion are at the same time those in the handling of which the race exercises and develops its powers. *Sympathy* becomes the uniting bond between the race's simultaneously and successively living individuals; it rises above mere instinct when it is purified by the thought of the great common task on which all work, at all times and under all conditions. *Reason* now becomes more than a purely

[*)] Cf. my lecture "Filosofien og Darwinismen" ("Nær og Fjern". 1874. Nr. 93—94).
[**)] Cf. *Herbert Spencer*: First Principles.

formal capacity; it acquires its living and full content through the contemplation of humanity's course of life, the laws and conditions under which it takes place, the tasks and duties that follow from these under given conditions.

Although human life thus has its ground in the life of the world, it is nevertheless a vanishing quantity in relation to the latter. The times are past when one could rest *[85]* content with the assumption that man was the center of the life of the world, and everything existed for his sake. The more thought has penetrated nature and learned to know its laws, and the more man, by the help of this insight, is able to use the forces of nature in his service, the more has the knowledge awakened at the same time that he himself, that the whole of human life, is only a vanishing element in relation to the great whole. The infinity of the life of the world and the unshakable laws according to which it unfolds convince him of his finitude and limitation. The feeling of dependence, in which the essence of religion has rightly been sought, will thus naturally arise also in him who does not live in faith in supernatural powers. But all fear and egoistic interest are excluded by the clear knowledge that what is to become reality rests not on the wishes and feelings of men, but on a definite order of things, expressed in fixed laws. He who strives for knowledge of himself and the conditions of his existence will therefore, as a "joyful link in the chain of the world order",[*)] in bold resignation leave to the course of nature what, and how much, of what he desires and hopes for is to be realized for him. When we hold fast that the highest we know, the ideal human ends and laws, has developed through this order of things, the feeling of dependence becomes reverence; the world order becomes not merely physical, but ethical. However vanishing human *[86]* life may be in relation to the life of the world, the highest goods we know have their place within it, and their worth is not diminished by our being unable to make sun, moon and stars stand still or change their course in order to serve them. We owe life and existence far too much to make such demands. In our deep dependence on nature we nevertheless feel gratitude and reverence for the great connection that has also let the fruits of spiritual life ripen.

The ethical thus stands in close connection with the religious. In both domains the feeling of reverence plays a leading role. The difference rests on this, that within the ethical, where man stands as acting, this feeling is attached to his own highest knowledge of ends and tasks, but in the religious he goes further back and sees his action, as well as his whole being, all his wishes and ends, as a link in the whole of human and natural life and subject to its conditions. So long as the feeling has not been extinguished in

[*)] *Dante*: Paradiset, 3rd Canto, 54th Verse.

humanity that the individual as well as the race are links in the infinite whole, issue from it and are conditioned by it, so long will the ethical and the religious also continue to assert themselves under various forms. We stand here before something that has its firm ground in man's nature and conditions, and that does not stand and fall with the commands of arbitrary powers.

## — The Ethical Law and Progress.

The adherents of the belief in authority praise it as one of the most important advantages *[87]*
of their principle that one learns directly from the source of truth what the good and the right are, so that the decision on this is not left to the changing opinions of times and individuals. This would certainly be a great advantage if the beings who were to act were incapable of striving themselves after a conviction in these questions, and if the chief weight were to be laid on a certain sum and kind of actions and not on the free disposition from which the actions spring. But when one sees man's highest powers stirring precisely in his striving after knowledge of his nature and his position in nature, one will grant Sir *William Hamilton* that a living error is better than a dead truth, and the living striving after ethical conviction itself becomes an important element in the ethical, without which the kingdom of harmonious personalities cannot be built up. The *[88]*
man who stands and listens for commands from outside before he can decide has not yet attained true personality. It will moreover always prove to be an illusion when one thinks that life is in reality governed by the commandment of the supernatural authority. This stands too far off to be able to make its way through in face of the actual conditions, where so many other forces — noble and ignoble — are stirring. "Not one Christian in a thousand," says *Stuart Mill* (Om Friheden, ch. 2), "lets the principles and precepts contained in the New Testament be a guide and test for his individual conduct. The standard by which he directs himself is what is custom and usage in his nation, his class of society, his religious profession. He thus has, on the one hand, a collection of ethical principles which he believes an infallible wisdom has given him as rules by which he is to direct his conduct; but on the other hand he has a collection of everyday opinions and directions which on the whole are a compromise between the Christian faith and the interests and promptings of actual life, in that they to a certain degree agree with some of those principles, do not agree so much with others of them, and finally stand in direct conflict with certain of them. To the first of these guides he gives his homage; by the second he in reality directs himself." But it is not only tradition and habit that can thus hinder the influence of the unconditional authority; the free, independent conviction *[89]*
about the demands of humanity also plays more and more a considerable role, to which the whole social development of modern times sufficiently testifies. Here, then, is visible proof that a firm insight into the ethical can really be acquired in a free and human way.

To overlook this source in order to seek another would be to cross the stream to fetch water.

Only then can one rightly praise the principle of authority for its certainty and clarity, when it is possible in every single case to get an answer to one's questions. The Catholic Church affords its adherents this advantage. The Catholic can in all cases of doubt turn to his confessor, who stands as the representative of the Church and thus, in the last instance, of God, as a pipe through which the flow from the source of absolute truth is led to him, the individual. Protestantism forgoes this certainty and clarity when it refers each individual to his inner conviction, and it takes up a wavering and untenable position when it would remedy this by ascribing to the Church a relative infallibility (*Martensen's* "Katholicisme og Protestantisme"). A relative infallibility is not infallibility. For the Protestant, conscience in reality becomes the only guide, and he can follow the Church only where it agrees with conscience. Protestantism takes a step forward with respect to ethical emancipation, but remains standing halfway. This comes out
*[90]* characteristically in the oldest Protestant moral theologians, who taught that conscience "in respect of power and authority stands midway between God and man: under God, but above man." Here the possibility is still hinted at of an authority that could stand above conscience, and it is this possibility that separates Protestant ethics from humane ethics.

If it stands fast that man can be bound only in conscience, by free recognition and feeling of the right, then conscience itself is the highest authority, and subordinate to no other whatsoever. Conscience, after all, means the highest degree of clarity and inwardness to which man's ethical thinking and feeling has attained by every possible exertion. Since it is now man himself who is to act, and man as he is under certain given conditions, he can seek the standard for his action only in the highest understanding of the nature and significance of the action that it is possible for him to gain. We must therefore grant *Johann Gottlieb Fichte* his bold proposition: "Conscience never errs and cannot err." It holds for man in the moment of action. If the better insight comes before the action, it will if possible prevent it; and if it comes after the action, it comes as a judge who must nevertheless acknowledge that the man did right in acting according to his best conviction. It is a duty to have a conscience; man must strive after a clear and definite conviction about the right. At every given stage he must decide according
*[91]* to the insight that stands at his disposal, while he carefully seeks to remedy his limited knowledge by anticipating and imagining how the action would look from a higher point of view. But since this higher point of view itself is always modified by the actual standpoint and circumstances of the one acting, which he is able to look away from only

in part, the possibility is never excluded that the action may later, under other conditions, look different to him. Nevertheless, if he really acted from conviction, he will see that the later, clearer and more correct insight itself became possible only through his having applied his imperfect insight at the earlier stage as well as he was able. Both stages thus lie on one and the same line, mark stages of the development toward one and the same goal.

What holds for the individual holds for the human race as a whole. The various human stages of development mark just as many various stages in the knowledge of the ethical law. One cannot maintain that unity prevails among men in ethical principles; experience and history refute that. Unity is not the starting point but the final goal. But what appears everywhere, as soon as a certain human development has been reached, is the relation of obligation itself. This can be present with greater or less clarity and inwardness, depth and range. What in one place is drawn under this relation is regarded in another place as indifferent. As soon as a higher stage has been reached, judgment is passed on the lower, through which it has nevertheless itself become possible. In so *[92]* far, history is the judgment in the life of the race as well as in that of the individual. An absolute truth we grasp nowhere. It is our lot to work at the solution of an infinite riddle, which presents itself under ever new forms as long as life lasts.

We are hereby led to the question whether one has the right to assume an advance in the ethical respect in the human race. This assumption, to which so much in our preceding investigations must lead us, has been rejected, by holding chiefly to the inner, subjective side of the ethical. Thus the famous naturalist *Wallace*, who knows the Malay race thoroughly, declares that the savages fulfil their simple moral law at least as well as the civilized Europeans, indeed that the mass of our population has not got beyond the moral law of the savages, but in certain respects has even sunk below it. One has gone a step further, in rejecting the thought of a properly ethical progress as containing an injustice, since the later generations, which began their course at a higher ethical stage of development, would then be more fortunately placed than the earlier ones. Since in the ethical what essentially matters is what one makes of the given conditions, it makes no difference at which stage one begins. Under the simplest and the most developed conditions of culture, morality can thus be the same. On this way of looking at things, which in our time has been maintained by *Bouillier*, the ethical is the same at all times: *[93]* numerator and denominator may vary, but the fundamental ratio remains the same. (1/2 = 2/4 = 3/6 = 4/8 etc.).

One here assumes that the ethical relation is present even at the lowest human stage

of development. But the ethical relation presupposes definite conditions, which cannot always have been present. It cannot be definitely shown before society and the relation of authority have formed, and before man's spiritual capacities have reached a certain strength and a certain range. Originally man distinguishes between good and evil only as between that which brings him joy and that which brings pain. Thus a savage explained that when someone took his wife from him, it was evil, but when he took another man's wife, it was good. And after the ethical relation has come into force as recognition of a higher law and action from reverence for it, it will take on a very different character under the different historical circumstances. The ethical is not something isolated in man's nature, does not stand indifferent to his development or decline in all other respects, but enters into the most intimate and lively interaction with everything else that stirs in man. The range, the purity and freedom with which the ethical asserts itself will always to a certain degree depend on the stage of culture and spiritual development that man has attained. With a clearer understanding of the goal and the conditions, the
*[94]* obligation itself must also take on a higher character. Even as regards the fundamental ethical relation, we must therefore assume an advance. But an entirely different question from this is whether the later generations thereby gain any advantage over the earlier ones. The conditions under which development begins for the several generations and individuals are not in their own power. We naturally occupy a higher standpoint than those on whose shoulders we stand, but that we do so we owe precisely to them. And the more the connection between the generations comes forward into consciousness, the more, in particular, the educating authority of the preceding generation over the one growing up is seen in its whole significance, the more will piety also be awakened toward all those who, each in his own way, have fought and worked to set us where we now stand.

The necessity of assuming an ethical advance is seen still more clearly when we look to the objective side of the matter, to the forms of life and institutions in which the ethical procures itself expression. The freer and more human way itself in which the conditions of life are gradually ordered and arranged for men must surely be of higher ethical worth than the crude and primitive arrangements. It is accumulated labor, which, like all capital, can certainly be both used and misused, but which nevertheless represents a fund at the disposal of the human race.

From the ethical point of view we regard the history of the human race as the history of the development of the harmonious society, the progressive realization of the kingdom
*[95]* of humanity. Within this development one can distinguish three stages; in the first might

rules, in the second right, in the third duty. These stages can be shown for the race as a whole as well as in the ethical development of each single individual and within the several humane and social spheres.

No education takes place without compulsion and without the use of punishment. Even the most philanthropic educator must in practice use compulsion, in order to prevent his ward from actions that would be absolutely and immediately harmful to himself or others, and the ward will often for the time being receive no other impression of this than of any use whatever of superior force. In primitive social life, where the philanthropic expresses itself only weakly, might rules almost completely, guided by the impulse of self-preservation of the mighty. All labor is loaded onto the weak, onto women and children. The vanquished enemy is treated like any other booty. Only within the tribe does one recognize the right of other individuals to exist and to satisfy their interests, and this recognition itself has been extorted by might. Right rests originally on recognition of the given relation of might. Within the family, where the relation of right does not assert itself, might continues to rule, as is seen in particular in the older Roman law, which subjects wife and children completely to the authority of the father of the family. When compassion for the weak, which is developed and nourished precisely within the family, leads to the defenseless enemy no longer being killed, he is made a slave and as such still has no more share than wife and children in the relation of right. *[96]* The master still stands toward him in the state of nature; war smoulders behind peace, as is seen from such laws as the one in Rome which ordained that all of a man's slaves were to be killed when he had been murdered, if they had at the time been so near that they could hear his cries.[*)] This law sprang, as *Montesquieu* aptly remarks,[**)] from the law of war, only that here the enemies were in the interior of society. How the slaves were treated depended partly on the master's disposition, partly on external circumstances. Of Cato the Elder it is told that he let his slaves judge one another among themselves, thus establishing a kind of relation of right among them of his own good will. But when suspicion constantly stood in the background, when the master felt himself the one among the many, full security could never come about. The humanity with which the slaves were nevertheless on the whole treated among the Greeks and Romans certainly had its ground not only in these peoples' humane and liberal way of thinking, but also in the difficulty of procuring new slaves, just as, conversely, the torments of the Negro slaves sprang in great part from the ease with which they could be replaced, and which made the masters find their account in letting them work themselves to death and then

[*)] Cf. *Tacitus*: Annales XIV, 42—44 (cf. XIII, 32.)

[**)] L'esprit des lois XI, 16.

buying new ones.[***)]

[97] The importance of the relation of might being replaced by the relation of right rests on right's opening the way to a grounding. The first element in the nature of right is certainly the sanction on the part of the power of society, which undertakes to uphold everyone in the possession and enjoyment of what he is and has. But with this a regulation, an evening-out of accidents and inequalities, is necessarily combined. A general standard and definite principles are sought for the decision of the single cases; but this must in turn lead to reasons being given for the single provisions. The old Roman jurists therefore sought to prove the lawfulness of slavery.[*)] They started from the premise that it is permitted to kill one's adversary in war; if I nevertheless spare him after having destroyed his power of resistance, he becomes my property. They derived the word servus (slave) from servare (preserve), and in this way presented slavery as a progress in humanity, which it in reality also was in relation to cannibalism and the bestial raging against the disarmed enemy. This grounding was still recognized in modern times by the first philosophers of law (*Grotius*, *Hobbes*, *Locke*). It was reserved for the 18th century to deal this institution the decisive blow. *Montesquieu* overthrew the old grounding by the simple objection that over a disarmed enemy, who can no longer
[98] do any harm, one reasonably has no other right than that of securing oneself against renewed danger.[*)]

By carrying through the line of thought that had thus been set in motion, and
[99] through the enthusiasm for humanity and the respect for individuality that were thereby awakened, one arrived in the last century at the idea of universal and innate rights of man, which were formulated variously by the various parties and in the various

[***)] *Stuart Mill*: Principles of political economy. II, 5,1.

[*)] *Hugo Grotius*: De jure belli et pacis III, 7, 5; 11, 16.

[*)] "The 17th century had no doubt with regard to slavery. Bossuet accepted it without hesitation as a fact authorized by Scripture. Locke did indeed combat it, but without originality and force, and he even retained it in certain cases (criminals and prisoners of war). The only discussion of it before Montesquieu that deserves to be remembered is Bodin's in the 16th century. He was the only one in that century who had raised his voice against slavery. As for the Middle Ages, there was unanimity with regard to this institution, which Christianity seemed to have destroyed. One must go back to the Church Fathers and the Stoics to find so lively a protest as that of the 18th century. But the Church Fathers, who relied only on the religious equality of men, and who in the name of human right permitted what they rejected in the name of mystical and Christian right, had not cut the root of this pernicious evil. Hence it came about that, despite all the mitigations of slavery, which had been transformed into serfdom, everything was ready for a renewal of this evil, which had indeed been diminished but not destroyed, when the discovery of America and of men with black skin gave occasion to greed, superstition and ignorance. The voice of the doctors and the theologians was not raised, with the exception of Las Cacas's, against this attack on the right of man. One must therefore say that it is only the 18th century that has dealt slavery a mortal blow; it is Montesquieu who has had this courage and this honor; enlightened by him, by J. J. Rousseau and others after them, the nations of Europe have resolved to free themselves from this stain." *Paul Janet*: Histoire de la science politique. 2e. éd. II. p. 504—505.

constitutions, and which *Kant* in his doctrine of right reduced to a single one: "Freedom (independence of every other's compelling arbitrariness), in so far as it can coexist with every other's freedom according to a universal law, is the only, original right which belongs to every man by virtue of his human nature." It is, as one sees, the same principle that *Stuart Mill* in our day has so energetically and urgently enjoined in his book "om Friheden." Kant saw the significance of this principle expressed in the fact that every restriction of personal freedom must be defended, whereas freedom in itself needs no grounding. But precisely for that reason this principle leads us beyond the proper sphere of right. For in so far as any meaning at all can be connected with words such as "innate right" or "right of man," it is an ethical rather than a juridical meaning. That everyone is to be treated as a free personality is an ethical demand which cannot in this form be fixed as an external law. But in addition, a purely formal conception of this principle would precisely hinder its being carried through. For it starts from the premise that everyone really is a free personality, fit to have his center in himself — but this is very far from being the case. Freedom cannot be "innate," it must be acquired. By hastily *[100]* recognizing men as free, one will precisely hinder them from becoming so. It was also soon seen, when the intoxication of enthusiasm over the "rights of man" was past, that it is of little use to give man rank as a free being when one does not help him really to become one. Here lies the social problem of our day, which in its manifold forms touches all spheres, from religion, science and school to property, industry and machinery. It is so comprehensive precisely because it does not concern any single side of human life, but the full development of personal life in all. Never before has the consciousness of what is at stake been so lively.

We are hereby led to the conviction that the concept of right must be subordinated to the concept of duty. Right consists essentially in society's sanction of the individual's position of power. Right can separate individuals and can cause them to regard society as a means to their private ends. During the struggle against despotism a firm point of support was found in the individual's absolute right of property. Property is an atom! — exclaimed the elder *Pitt* in Parliament. But we know of no absolute atoms. No atom is released from the general laws of the whole nexus within which it finds itself. And just as the right to property presupposes the sanction of the power of society, so property itself must, from an ethical point of view, be seen as grounding a relation of duty. *Auguste Comte* has earnestly combated the modern distinction between the private and the public; *[101]* in his view everyone ought to regard himself as a public functionary. Through property the individual, as through his external position in general, has been assigned a sphere

and means for work in the service of the tasks of the history of civilization. The ends of the history of civilization comprise everything that contributes to the development and advancement of mankind in inner and outer respects. Life and activity in the family, in civil society and in the state, in the world of art and of science, of industry and of commerce, serve this end. And by working in these spheres the individual lives his way into the feeling that he is a member of a great organism, a citizen in a kingdom of humanity that works its way forward in the course of the ages. His proper self he then finds in the task that falls to him within this development. The validity and significance of the personality are conditioned by the value of the content and the interests in which it lives. The one individual can assert itself and demand recognition from the other only by establishing the significance of what it lives in and for. The true personality is developed by work for ends and tasks set by the actual world. Reality is more than a stage on which the individuals are to present themselves in order to show their virtuosity. When the monks in the Egyptian desert spent their time watering dry sticks that were planted in the sand, this could be a lesson in ascetic self-surrender and serve as a symbol
*[102]* of the insignificance of human activity in face of the supernatural world. But the vital nerve of humane ethics is, as we have seen from several sides, the intimate connection between the individual and the race, and therefore also between the individual and the actual world.[*)] This relation must not be made into a sham relation, which it must always become under dualistic presuppositions. The miracle conflicts with ethics just as much as with physics and logic.

There is a harmony between personality and the ethical tasks. Personality is developed by work on the solution of the tasks, and conversely the task consists, directly or indirectly, in the development of personal life. A society consists in a plurality, a manifoldness, which is bound into unity by peculiar laws. The more freely and independently
*[103]* the single members move, the more different possibilities they realize, while at the same time the unity is preserved and constantly gains a more intimate character and higher validity, the more perfect is the society. The idea of the human race as the kingdom of personalities, as a living unity of individual forces, is therefore the highest ethical idea. It

[*)] S. *Kierkegaard* has sought to maintain a complete opposition between ethics and history, and from his standpoint rightly. "God could, without doing wrong and without denying his nature, which is love, create a man endowed with capacities like no other, and set him in an out-of-the-way place and say to him: Live through now, in exertion like no other, the human; work, so that the half could be enough to transform a contemporary age, but you and I, we remain alone about it; all your striving shall have no significance whatever for any other human being, and yet you shall, do you understand, you shall will the ethical, and you shall, do you understand, you shall be enthusiastic, because this is the highest." Uvidenskabelig Efterskrift p. 98. — From the ascetic point of view obedience, which is here the cardinal virtue, shines the more brightly the smaller the result is. Whether one transforms a contemporary age or waters a withered stick comes in any case to the same. Cf. above p. 71.

is to it that the one who acts ethically, consciously or unconsciously, under the one form or the other, looks when he weighs and appraises ends and means. It is not the fruit of arbitrary speculation, but is an ideal that has formed itself for human consciousness in the course of history[*)], thought fetching, in artistic fashion, the elements of the image of the perfect from imperfect reality, an ideal whose partial, progressive realization can be shown.

But progress does not go in a straight line, and not all parts of the human race share in it. This might seem to be a weighty objection against the whole idea of progress. Yet one must not, over the reactionary periods, forget the essential tendency, the law, that reveals itself when one compares a series of periods, especially as reaction itself proves to be an important member in the development, which enriches it with new experiences and firmer forms. All motion is rhythmic, but that does not exclude its being progressive. "Where many different elements take part in the motion, the same state will never quite *[104]* return. A political reaction never brings back the old order of things. The rationalism of our time is very different from that of the last century."[*)] And as regards the unequal participation of the different races in progress, the case here is as within the animal world, where the development of the type in some groups stops at a point that for other groups stands only as a point of transition. The human fetus shows at early stages a likeness to lower types. So it goes with the civilization of peoples; the one people stops at a stage that is known from other peoples' history as a standpoint overcome. Thus many oriental societies have stopped at the stage of development where the civil and the ecclesiastical government still coincide. One can perhaps even say, if one disregards the highest stages of culture, that stagnation is the rule and progress the exception.[**)] Only a small part of mankind has reached a higher civilization. But whereas the more highly developed animal species is unable to give the lower species a share in the results of its development, such a communication is possible within the human world. European culture seems destined to become universal, to take the other forms of culture up into itself, although the meeting with these more primitive forms of culture cannot yet be said on the whole to have had a very humane character. Europeans still have toward the *[105]* inhabitants of other parts of the world no small degree of the self-esteem and national pride that the ancients cherished toward the barbarians. Yet this barrier too will one day fall, all rivers will unite in one great stream, and a single community of culture will

[*)] Cf. my essay: "Forestillingen om Retfærdighed i dens historiske Hovedformer." Nationaløkonomisk Tidsskrift. 2det Bind p. 81—116.

[*)] *Spencer*: First principles. Part II. chap 10: The rhythm of motion.

[**)] *Maine*: Ancient Law p. 22.

embrace all the inhabitants of the earth.

At the ethical standpoint one has no time to dwell on the thought of how much has been accomplished ("wie wir's so herrlich weit gebracht"), just as little as one has time to brood over what could have been otherwise. The pressure of what remains to be done will even, as a rule, at any time be so strong that men will be reluctant to admit that they are happier than their forefathers. The good old time, of whose vices and sufferings one has no living feeling, but in whose virtues and goods one believes, is therefore as a rule extolled at the expense of the present time. Men have for the most part felt themselves to be in the iron age and placed the golden age in the past. Our time seems especially to be the time of pessimism. This can be derived from several causes. The great political and social reforms in the last century were greeted with expectations of a golden age of freedom which have not been fulfilled — among other things for the simple reason that those who were emancipated, by the nature of the case, still lacked the education that only freedom itself can give. The great upswing in industry and commerce has not been accompanied by the right distribution of all the goods that were thereby obtained. The
*[106]* advanced intellectual culture has called forth a reflection and a consciousness which the primitive peoples lack, and which can often hinder the free and full enjoyment of what is valuable in life, while it sharpens the sense for the disharmonious and for the shadow sides. In the ethical respect, however, precisely hereby a great advance has been made, in the direction of sympathy with the suffering of others. A personal experience of pain is necessary in order that sympathy with the pain of others may gain the right strength and extent. And the urgent consciousness of what remains to be done presupposes the idea of the high goal that was to be reached. Pessimism itself will thus, where it is more than the fruit of the disappointed hopes of a refined craving for enjoyment, lead to a clearer conception of the conditions of human life and to the feeling of how important it is that work be done toward their perfection. In the ethical principle, as it has been developed in the foregoing, is contained the possibility of reconciling work and enjoyment, the morality of duty and the morality of utility. The fundamental ethical task is, as we have seen, to develop harmony within the individual personality as well as between the single persons in society; but the highest happiness consists precisely in such a harmony, in the development of the personal powers in concord with one another. —

The ethical relation will not disappear again as long as the fundamental conditions of human life remain the same. It owes its origin and its activity in mankind to definite
*[107]* conditions, but these conditions are, as we have sought to show, the same as those on which the existence and development of the race itself depend. The forms under which

the ethical appears may vary without its changing in its innermost nature. Only if it coincided entirely with the relation to the external authorities would its role be played out when emancipation triumphs; then we should already now be witnesses of its process of dissolution. Advancing culture leads men to look with irony on all authority, and if with this they reject everything that grew up in its shelter in the course of the ages, the ethical too will disappear. But in the blasé mood that so easily arises in the transition from one great principle to another, one must not see the final result of the course of development. A closer investigation of the psychological and historical foundation of the ethical leads to the recognition not only of its great and lasting significance, but also of its inner connection with the fundamental laws of mankind.

## Freedom of the Will.

*[108]* The recognition of the ethical law differs from theoretical insight and aesthetic contemplation in this, that it makes a demand on us. But here the question then naturally arises how far man is able to satisfy this demand, or the question of the freedom of the human will. This too is a problem that concerns the foundation of ethics, for which reason we must still give a brief indication of how it is to be understood from the standpoint set out in the foregoing. It is with deliberate intent that this inquiry is undertaken only now; for however disputed the questions with which we have occupied ourselves in the preceding chapters may be, the problem of the freedom of the will nevertheless seems to have a peculiar sting. This has its ground in part in the fact that the psychology of the will is still so little cleared up; the will is perhaps the most intricate side of man's nature,
*[109]* where very many conscious and unconscious factors play a part, while the development of cognition and of the life of feeling is simpler and easier to follow. But it must surely be derived chiefly from the fact that people in general believe they know extraordinarily well how matters stand with this question, for which reason one is easily repelled by the divergent results of a theoretical inquiry. The supposed knowledge hinders the growth of right insight not only by excluding the need for it, but also by favoring feelings that make it impossible to consider the matter in an unbiased way.

Wherever we seek to understand and explain a thing, we must go back to the larger connection within which it comes into being. We must see it develop and consider its relation to the other things that are links in the same chain. This procedure we have followed in the preceding inquiries, and we will also apply it in the present one. By thus seeing the thing develop, one more easily discovers the elements contained in its nature; the different stages in the development are marked precisely by new elements attaching themselves to those previously given, and by the connection between the given elements taking on another character. But herein lies, then, that in order to understand a thing we must dissolve (analyze) it. As it stands in its finished and completed unity it is incomprehensible. It must be broken apart, each of its parts must be considered by itself, and we must then see whether we can understand the working together of the parts, and so put together again what we have taken apart. Research often fares as children fare
*[110]* with their toys, which they too tear to pieces in order to study their hidden nature, but which they are not able to put together again. But this danger is amply outweighed when

the process of dissolution (analysis) merely teaches us to know some new elements; the first step is then taken and can draw more after it; we cannot, after all, expect to reach the goal in one day. The immediate apprehension, however, as a rule feels repelled and uneasy at this dissolution of what stands for it as a completed whole resting in itself, and in every domain inquiring thought has had to fight a hard battle to assert its right. It seems as if all individuality were threatened by research in a struggle of life and death. For the lifeless world one will nowadays no longer raise objection to the application of analysis; one will not readily speak of individuals here. Only to the imagination does a mountain or a distant island appear as an individual being. But in the organism many still believe they have an absolute individual, although *Goethe's* words: "Kein Lebendiges ist eins, immer ist es vieles", have received complete confirmation through the results of science, and hold not only for the organism as a whole, but also for its parts; even the cell, in which for a time one believed one had found the real individual, is a little world, and so on to infinity.

Must we then wholly give up the concept of individuality? Does not nature then dissolve for us into a chaos, where innumerable elements float about among one another and are joined only for a moment to form apparently fixed and completed shapes? This *[111]* conclusion springs only from the impatience of the imagination at having to give up the indissoluble unity with which it has endowed things. With far greater right we must turn the relation around and say that the whole activity of nature is individualizing. The analyzing inquiry seeks only the elements that in nature are joined into peculiar wholes. At all the different stages of the life of nature there form centers or nodal points, from which particular activities go forth. The nature of each of these peculiar activities depends on the reciprocal relation between the given center and the surrounding conditions. Already within the lifeless world there form smaller circles, which modify in a peculiar way the influences coming from without. Think, e.g., of the state of aggregation of substances and its dependence on temperature and pressure; in this definite relation to the conditions lies something individual. But greater independence, and therefore also the possibility of a further-reaching and deeper interaction with the surrounding world, we find first in living beings, which therefore mark a higher stage of individualization. The living being is able, through the freer and more intimate relation between its elements, to adapt itself in far higher degree to its surroundings — indeed, at the higher stages, even to adapt the surroundings to itself. Recent science, which lays a special weight on the relation between the organism and its conditions of existence, has thereby paved the way for a fuller conception of individuality, which was formerly often regarded as an

*[112]* isolated unity. It is in the manner in which there is reaction against certain conditions that individuality shows itself. The individual is not substance, but function. The greater or lesser richness and manifoldness of the interaction furnishes the standard for how high a being stands in the series of things. And it is through this interaction, too, that the transition, according to the most probable hypothesis, takes place from the lower to the higher forms. The struggle for existence consists in the individual's asserting itself in its peculiarity under the given conditions, and is thus a struggle for individuality.

From this point of view the mental life, too, stands in close connection with the whole development of nature. It marks the highest stage of individualization that we know. Consciousness is the condition for the reciprocal relation to the world taking on a comprehensive and deep-going character. The different influences from without must be gathered, remembered and combined; distinctions must be made between different kinds of influences, in order that the reaction may correspond exactly to that which calls it forth. But that gathering and this distinguishing can take place only in a consciousness. The different stages of the development of conscious life — "from the intestinal worm in an organic tissue to a Newton or Shakespeare, whose thought embraces the world" — are also stages of the development of individuality.

The human individual has, through its whole organization, the possibility of entering into a richer reciprocal relation with the surrounding world than the other living beings.
*[113]* Yet originally it, too, is only a side track, along which the movement from without is conducted further, without anything happening in the individual itself other than a mechanical propagation of the communicated impression from the sense organ to the central organ and from this to the organ of movement. This is the case with the so-called reflex movements. Here movement follows immediately upon impression, as when the pupil contracts under the impression of strong light, or when someone, without himself knowing it, chases away a fly that has settled on his cheek while he is absorbed in his work. Such movements, which are direct discharges or reflexes of the influence from without, can therefore also be carried out when the individual has been deprived of the most important organs of conscious life, as the many generally known experiments with frogs and salamanders prove. Robin even saw the arm of a beheaded criminal begin a warding-off movement when he scraped him on the chest with a scalpel. Even where the movement proceeds from the individual itself, as in the spontaneous and purposeless movements in which the nervous system seeks an outlet for its increased energy (see above p. 11), it still has a purely mechanical character. And yet in the capacity for spontaneous and reflex movement we must see the germ from which the will develops,

without its being possible to indicate the definite point where the involuntary ends and the voluntary begins. Of will we speak only when there has formed a fixed and coherent circle of ideas and feelings by which the individual's action is determined, so that the impression received or the spontaneous impulse is not immediately converted into outward-going activity. Before such a fixed core has formed in consciousness, we *[114]* do not ascribe to the individual any real self either. But the point at which such a self can be said to be present is reached through a long development, which begins with very few and very obscure ideas and feelings. Some physiologists have even assumed that a sensation takes place even in the pure reflex movements, although this does not come into our consciousness. So much is in any case certain, that no sharp boundary can be drawn between the involuntary and the voluntary movements. Even if sensations or ideas appear between the impression and the action that follows from it, the action can still be called purely mechanical in so far as the real self, i.e. the whole circle of thoughts and feelings that otherwise rules in the individual's consciousness, does not come into play at all. This is the case with all actions performed from habit, where we often act according to a quite distinct idea without this idea entering into interaction with the rest of the circle of ideas. It is on the whole the case in "unguarded moments", where attention is not awakened; we then do something other than we really want. But the greater the significance the interval between prompting and action acquires, the more reason there is to speak of a will. In this interval the prompting can be brought into connection with the rest of the content of consciousness and act upon the mental state as a whole. What thoughts and feelings it thereby awakens in the individual case *[115]* depends partly on the general psychological laws of the association and reproduction of ideas, partly on the individual's inborn temperament and his character as developed in the course of life. An effect can never be derived from a single cause, but always presupposes a whole series of conditions. The action becomes a consequence of the manner in which the individual's nature is modified by the impression or the prompting. The more restricted the circle of ideas is, the fewer possibilities present themselves to consciousness, and the more immediately the impression leads to action. The harder it is to set the circle of ideas in motion, so that images of memory can emerge, or thought turn toward the future, or in general toward objects that lie far from the situation given at the moment, the less developed is the will. Children and savages are therefore children of the moment, and let themselves be carried away immediately by the first prompting that comes along. Travelers emphasize as the most characteristic trait of savages their lack of capacity for steady and persevering work whose reward only the future is to

bring. Their feelings are quickly awakened, but last only a short time. They have, as has been said, the understanding of children and the passions of men. Without memory there is no coherence in conscious life, and therefore no real self either. Instead of distinguishing between voluntary and involuntary movements, one could therefore distinguish between movements that presuppose memory and reflection, and such as
*[116]* are performed immediately and without forethought. *Wundt* has rightly emphasized that animals which have been deprived of the central organs of consciousness lack memory, which is seen when one lets some time pass between the experiments; the same unsuitable movements are then made anew before the suitable ones are found. But the boundary remains always movable, since actions that were first performed with reflection are gradually performed wholly without forethought.

The will thus presupposes deliberation. Prior to the willed action there goes on a struggle in consciousness between different possibilities, different promptings to action, and the object of the will becomes the prompting that triumphs over the others. The richer and more strongly developed conscious life is, the more the action, too, can be called the individual's own, according as it is decidedly determined by his nature. The fixed core that has formed in consciousness will assert itself in every essential action that is to be performed, and stamp it with its impress. In other words, a character, a personality, has formed. Reason has, as Hamlet says, mingled with the impulse of the blood, "so that Fortune cannot, as on a flute, play on him whatever melody she pleases". The decision is not an immediate discharge, but the fruit of a process that has taken place in the individual's innermost nature, and to which all the elements in it have made their contribution.

*[117]* Every decision proceeds from the existing psychological presuppositions with the same necessity with which effect everywhere follows cause. But it is not any external power that overwhelms man; his own nature, his own self, asserts itself in the strongest motive in a particular form determined by the circumstances. It is man himself who acts. The agent may have a feeling that none of the motives that have asserted themselves to his consciousness contains the sufficient cause of the action. But that only shows that one must go deeper to the bottom to find the cause of the action. Behind the conscious motives lie the unconscious, inherited or acquired predispositions, which exert a decisive influence on our action. Hence it comes that we learn to know our own natural character only gradually, through experience; by what we do we learn, as *Schopenhauer* says, what we are, and we are often surprised in a high degree by the discoveries we make in this way.

In man's nature there lies, as we have seen earlier, an original impulse to activity; how it expresses itself is determined by the organization received from the hand of the race and of nature. The individual's own experiences and actions also leave behind them traces and after-effects, which assert themselves as predispositions and dispositions in certain definite directions. We thus never begin absolutely from the beginning in our action. As links in a great connection and in an infinite series of development we have our definite point of departure and our definite presuppositions, which are one with our *[118]* individual nature, our original character. Therefore the freedom of the will is wholly illusory if by it one understands a capacity to begin an action absolutely, to be cause without being effect. A cause that is not an effect, that is thus its own cause (causa sui), must be an absolute being, raised above all conditions, torn loose from the lawful order of things. But such a being is incomprehensible to us. Acute defenders of the absolute freedom of the will have also seen this; for them it is a postulate that cannot be grounded. But however much one recognizes the limitation of human knowledge, one cannot thus throw down the bridge in the midst of the world of phenomena. If the connection here is burst at a single point, it will be all over with all lawfulness and all knowledge of nature. Either one must make man a god, or else one must recognize that he arises and develops according to definite laws, which to a certain degree must be or become accessible to us. Experience now shows us clearly enough that he is a finite being, even if the individualizing process of nature has reached in him what we must regard as its highest point. Individuality rests here, as everywhere, on there forming a smaller, relatively closed circle within the larger, and on the influences coming from without being modified by the laws that hold for this smaller circle.

But just as surely as we first learn to know our character from our actions, just so surely is it also the case that our actions conversely contribute to determining and *[119]* developing our character. It is a physiological fact that the structure of an organ is developed by exercise. The result of activity is not merely the work accomplished outwardly; it is also the increased skill, the more developed disposition in a certain respect, that the individual has thereby attained. Every feeling, every decision, every action adds a stone to the building of man's character. And when such a spiritual development has now been reached that the individual can become conscious of this, as he begins to fulfill the Socratic demand: Know thyself! — then he will also be able to seek to guide the course of his ideas, feelings and decisions in the direction he regards as the best. Man stands over against inner nature just as he stands over against outer nature. He cannot work miracles. He cannot intervene in the course of things to guide

it according to his purposes, except in so far as he can learn to know the conditions under which things arise and act: if he can bring about these conditions, then he can also guide the phenomena of nature according to his will, e.g. divert the lightning bolt, or he can at least foresee their occurrence and take precautions against their consequences. It goes similarly with him in regard to his own nature. Here, too, he cannot create or work miracles. But if he has sufficient knowledge of himself, that is to say, of the manner
*[120]* in which his nature is affected by circumstances and conditions, then he can seek to change these conditions in order thereby also to change his own ideas and feelings and guide them in a certain direction. How far one can get along this path only experience can show. The limit will always be staked out by the original predispositions in man's nature; and only fantasticality will venture beyond it. Here, too, mastery shows itself in limitation. But much that, seen immediately, seems impossible can nevertheless be reached, if not directly then indirectly. We cannot act immediately on the movement of the heart, but by holding our breath and compressing the chest, or by chemical influence, we can modify its movement when we will. — "If one cannot leap over the Atlantic Ocean as over a ditch, one can still sail over it; and although Columbus was assured that it could not be done, and that anyone who attempted it must necessarily perish, he nevertheless did it and did not perish. In like manner transformations of character are possible, but, to be sure, only within the limits of a certain given natural endowment, and here, too, the execution requires time, courage and perseverance".[*)]

Everything depends on attention and interest being awakened. In the domain of cognition man is at first guided immediately by the impressions and by the associations
*[121]* of ideas that they call forth, but these often have nothing whatever to do with the actual connection of things. When he is led by experience to see this, attention is awakened, and he strives to form and connect his ideas in such a way that they correspond to reality. Consciousness is nowhere wholly passive. Activity is the condition for receptivity. Attention, which is of such great significance for cognition, is already a will.[*)] Painful experience is often the condition for its being awakened. In the domain of action as in that of cognition, man becomes wise through harm. The dominion of the immediate

[*)] *Fortlage*: Psykologiske Foredrag. Kbhvn. 1876. p. 187.

[*)] "Apperception [the mind's attentive grasp of something] and the impulse to voluntary movement are only different forms of the awakening of the will. — — The voluntary movements most probably proceed from the foremost parts of the brain, while the central organs of sensation seem chiefly to be found in the parts of the surface of the brain that lie further back. On the other hand, one can hardly doubt that the higher mental functions are bound chiefly to the development of the forebrain. This connection first becomes intelligible when we consider that the points of origin of the innervation of the will at the same time govern the centers of sensation, and thus determine not only the movements but the apprehension of sense impressions and the course of the reproduced ideas." *Wundt*: Physiologische Psychologie. p. 765 f.

natural impulse must often lead to decided conflict with what man holds fast as his right task, his true end, before a penetrating consciousness of the significance of the action can arise. When thought has awakened and the consciousness of a higher law has developed, a new impulse has awakened in man, which strives gradually to master his action. But it is only step by step that the opposition between the two tendencies *[122]* becomes clear; temptation itself will then, according to the law of the association of ideas, awaken the idea of the law against which it strives, and thereby make a struggle possible. The passion awakened by the impression of the moment will long continue to obscure the consciousness of the essential law.

"Noch ist, bei tiefer Neigung für das Wahre,
Ihm Irrthum eine Leidenschaft". (Goethe).

A condition for the idea of an essential law being able to form is, as we have seen earlier, that the individual has lived its way into the thought of the larger whole to which it belongs. This happens through education, and therefore education is also the presupposition of self-education. Man must be guided in order to be able to guide himself. Freedom in the sense of a capacity for self-education can come into being only where this condition is fulfilled. Here again we see how closely the single individual is bound to the whole; what he is capable of depends on his relation to it. It is only the fully developed individual that can be free in the sense in which we here take this word.

In defense of the assumption of absolute freedom, of the capacity to be cause without being effect, one appeals as a rule partly to the general consciousness, the immediate feeling, partly to remorse and to accountability.

The immediate consciousness and feeling can decide nothing here. It teaches us only *[123]* what we feel and imagine, but not how the feeling and the idea have arisen, or in what relation they stand to the actual connection of things. It grounds no theory, neither in the one direction nor in the other; it is only reflective thinking that poses the problem and seeks an explanation. The immediate consciousness is not wrong in asserting that we ourselves are the cause of our actions; what it is wrong about is that we should be absolute cause, cause without being effect. It assumes this because it does not feel itself compelled or set in motion from without when it decides, in the same way as it assumes that the earth stands still because the motion is not noticed. We do not ourselves notice the motion of our will, any more than we notice that of the earth; in both cases we infer the motion. Nowhere is there anything that moves without itself being moved.

We have shown earlier how the higher stage of life passes judgment on the lower. Just as the history of the world is the judgment of the world, so the history of the

individual man is the judgment on himself. We measure our earlier action by the more perfect knowledge and feeling of the right that we have since attained. In the calm and harmonious mood we pass judgment on what we did while passion ruled us. Thus we apply an ideal standard to ourselves, a standard taken from another standpoint than
*[124]* the one from which the action was done. The pain that arises from the feeling of the opposition between our actual action and the ideal action we call remorse. Remorse thus becomes intelligible and is seen in its great ethical significance even if we assume no absolute freedom. It consists, on our view, in the penetrating and painful feeling of *not yet* having got further. How strong and intense this feeling is depends on the strength and clarity with which the idea of the ideal, of the obligating law, appears. Remorse points forward; it is the birth pangs of the ethical character, a testimony to our predisposition to development. If it were to presuppose that we could also have acted otherwise under the given circumstances, it would in any case be a wholly idle consideration to dwell on, and *Fichte* would be right in his energetic remark that we have no time to repent. The value of remorse rests partly on the idea of the right becoming clearer and stronger through the deep feeling of the wrong, partly on the closer knowledge of himself that man gains through it. What has happened cannot be undone, but the new possibilities that present themselves through self-knowledge act as a spur and drive forward. From the standpoint of humane ethics it may therefore hold: felix culpa! (happy guilt!)

As for accountability, finally, it rests on man's being so developed that there has formed a self, a fixed core in his consciousness, which can determine his action. On
*[125]* the other hand, it presupposes no absolute freedom. However much I may be able to give an exhaustive explanation of my action, may see the connection and necessity of all the motives, I must nevertheless reject it and impute it to myself when I see its disagreement with what I recognize as the highest law of human action, and when I was in full possession of my reason when I performed it. The motives were, after all, not foreign to me; they were precisely the expression of my nature and proceeded from it with necessity under the given circumstances. How else could the action be my own? If at a single moment I could act in such a way that the action had nothing whatever to do with my actual nature, did not proceed from it with necessity, my personality would split into many parts. It is true that one rightly distinguishes between man's real self or true will and the manner in which he shows himself in his actual action, and the Apostle Paul indeed even says: "I do not do the good that I will, but the evil that I do not will; but when I do what I do not will, then it is no longer I who do it, but the sin that dwells in me." (Epistle to the Romans VII, 19—20). But one must not confuse a figurative

opposition with a real separation. What we call the real or true self could also be called the ideal self, the character as it would be if it were freed from its imperfections. But it has no existence except in the actual self itself. Our faults are "the faults of our virtues", and it is only to excuse ourselves that we take our "better self" for our real self. *[126]*

Accountability, like remorse, points forward, not back. That I recognize myself as accountable with regard to a certain action means that I feel the obligation to work further in order to get beyond the imperfection that the action has brought to light. I feel myself liable to renewed education. Freedom in the sense of a capacity for self-education is, as we have remarked, possible only when an education has gone before. It is a capacity that presupposes certain definite conditions. When the clarity and liveliness of consciousness, whether on account of youth, of insanity, or of passing abnormal states, are not present in such a degree that man can "look forward and back", consider the nature and consequences of the action, then the juridical law does not regard him as accountable either; and it is a sign of the growing psychological insight that the newer penal codes lay greater weight on the influence of such circumstances than the older ones (compare e.g. the Penal Code of 1866 with Christian V's Danish Law). A normal and fully developed conscious life is the condition of accountability. This condition is not present in children, whose education is not completed, nor in the insane, or rather, it is found in them only at a lower stage. For the child, too, is called to account and punished for what lies within its ethical domain; and as for the insane, *Maudsley* has aptly remarked that *[127]* one must assume a certain responsibility in them, since in the asylums one acts upon the insane through the usual motives, although one does not punish them as fully responsible when these motives do not gain power over them.[*)] Accountability is thus relative, varies with conditions and circumstances. Fully developed ("grown-up and sound of mind") persons are compelled by society to obey its laws. This too is an education toward a definite end and presupposes accountability only in the sense that there must not be anything in the persons that excludes the possibility of reaching this goal. He who, under otherwise normal conditions, proves in deed to lack respect for the law of society must be brought to recognize it by feeling its power. Our psychological-ethical standpoint

[*)] *Maudsley*: Le crime et la folie. p. 190. — Cf. *Griesinger*: Pathologie und Therapie der psychischen Krankheiten. 2te Aufl. p. 479: "In the asylums the patient's outward restlessness and the audible expression of his morbid impulses are checked already by the example of the other patients, by the prevailing spirit of peace and order; he is drawn of himself into the calm movement of the whole house; possible resistance on his part is met not so much by direct compulsion as by his own feeling of submission to the imposing power of the whole. Here he finds forbearance and attention, but also notices that obstinacy would not help; he soon learns to comply with the physician's arrangements and sees how the manner in which he is treated, the measure of freedom and enjoyment that can fall to his share, depends on his composure and conduct. Thus he finds here essential help toward self-control."

*[128]* thus leads us to agreement with the manner in which Professor Goos in his "Indledning til den danske Strafferet" (p. 60—64) has grounded the penal authority of the state.[*)] From a juridical standpoint one certainly cannot regard education in the sense of ethical improvement as the end of punishment, since the power of the state has no right to intervene in the individual's innermost personal life. Nor, after all, does the medical treatment of the insane aim at improving them, but only at restoring the old self in its health; and *Griesinger* finds in this the difference between education and the treatment of the insane. What society must demand is practical recognition of its authority, and by punishment such recognition is compelled where it has proved to be lacking. By punishment, as Prof. Goos says, the criminal's character is bent to obedience to the law. "The encroachment on the person's legal goods, the suffering that punishment contains, aims at supplying the person with new and stronger motives for the disciplining of his character to obedience to the law, after it has proved that the disciplining left to himself has not brought about what the power of society requires in this respect." Prof. Goos draws from this result the conclusion that, as a presupposition for the justification of punishment, accountability is not required in the sense of a capacity for absolute freedom, "freedom of the will in the sense that the application of the law of causality
*[129]* to human acts of will, or the conception of the relation between motives and decision as the relation between cause and effect, is excluded." The necessary presupposition is only that disciplining by human effort is not impossible, and it is not so as long as it is still possible to awaken the man's self-feeling, his attention to himself, his capacity for energy and resignation. Only he can be liable to education in whom it is possible at all. The crime gives society the right to educate the criminal. The criminal's relation to authority sinks back, on account of his own deed, to the starting point; since he does not feel reverence, he must feel fear.

We have earlier insisted that the single individual can never be isolated from the larger context in which it arises and develops. Nevertheless it was such an isolation that was presupposed by the manner in which punishment was regarded in older times. Whether one wished by it to threaten and deter, to requite eye for eye and tooth for tooth, or to propitiate an angry deity, the criminal stood as the enemy of the whole society, as one toward whom one no longer had any duty. In great part this way of regarding it doubtless sprang from the passionate feeling of revenge, which sees the offense as absolute and therefore admits no limitation; but the dogma of the absolute freedom of the will has also exercised its influence here. It dissolves the race into individuals, into

[*)] The present treatise was essentially finished when Prof. Goos's book appeared, but it was a great encouragement and confirmation to me to find a kindred line of thought in this acute work.

absolutely independent starting points. As soon, on the other hand, as one sees the deep *[130]*
connection between the individual, in the whole range of his nature and his character, and the whole race and society, it must also appear impossible that anything whatever should be able wholly to loosen this connection. As the crime itself often points back to disproportions and defects in the life of society, so on the other side it must be the task of society not to annihilate, but to help forward and develop the germs of truly human life that may be hidden even in the apparently most hardened mind; it thereby works for its own cause, its own development.

The freedom of the will, as we recognize it, does not conflict with necessity. The validity of the natural laws embraces ethical action too. By the freedom of the will we understand the state in which man's reason and feeling, and his spiritual capacities in general, are so developed that a single impression, a single feeling or passion, does not completely dominate him or prevent reflection and deliberation, the application of the standard that stands for him as the highest. Freedom is thus here the opposite not of necessity but of blindness and chance. It makes self-control and self-education possible. But whether we regard freedom as a capacity or as a state, it is always relative. Our freedom consists in a striving to become free. Few are the points at which the individual really unfolds full activity. The further his development in this respect has advanced, the greater too will be the contribution that his self-conscious action makes to *[131]*
the formation of character. And when the feeling for the significance of this contribution is sharpened, when attention is drawn with force in this direction, consciousness forms for itself an ideal model in which the contribution from the conscious action of the personality becomes so great that the other elements vanish in relation to it, — the ideal of perfect freedom, of what the human personality would be if all hindering conditions and influences were thought away. This ideal is only a special form of the general ethical law, which, as shown earlier, consists in the idea of perfect human life as that which develops through the ages. In this idea the image of action springing freely, i.e. from man's conscious personality, is also a necessary element; it expresses the form of activity that accords with man's place in the series of natural beings.

But this ethical *ideal* the common conception confuses with the *actual* will, which is always conditioned. Perfect freedom we conceive by abstraction and idealization. The thought of it acts, like every ideal, as a spur and incitement; but it rests on an illusion when one transforms it into a capacity that is supposed to be present in all and under all circumstances. Such an illusion is nothing unique, but has in every domain hindered the conception of natural development. One refuses to recognize the perfect as the result *[132]*

of a development and regards it as being there from the first. Thus one conceives the soul as a being by itself that is implanted in the body, and the fully developed body as already present in the germ en miniature. What development itself first leads to must in one way or another have been there from the beginning. One has thereby come to ascribe to all men at every moment, as a capacity, what is in itself only the goal of a long development.

Most attempts to maintain the absolute freedom of the will do not exactly have such a scientific form that they invite closer discussion. Only one form of the absolute doctrine of freedom will it be worth while to bring forward here, namely *Kant's*, since he is the most eminent of the inquirers to whom one will be able to appeal in this matter. Here there is now, in the first place, the remarkable circumstance that Kant himself with great emphasis stresses the natural necessity of human willing and acting, in so far as man's being is accessible to us through experience. In psychology Kant is decidedly a determinist. "All the actions of man in the world of experience," he says in "Kritik der reinen Vernunft," "are determined by his empirical character and the other co-operating causes according to the order of nature, and if we could investigate all his voluntary actions to their ultimate ground, there would not be a single human action that we could not predict and recognize as a necessary consequence of the preceding
*[133]* conditions. With regard to this empirical character there is therefore no freedom, and yet only according to this character can we regard man when we merely wish to *observe*, and, as happens in anthropology, investigate physiologically the moving causes of his action." It is the same fundamental conception that we have sought to carry through in the foregoing. Kant was so permeated by the spirit of determinism that in his doctrine of method he maintains that even the wildest hypotheses, if only they keep within the domain of natural causes, are preferable to the appeal to the supernatural, which serves "lazy reason" only as a pretext for giving up the labor of finding the causes by way of experience. But according to Kant's whole conception of the ethical, this does not belong at all to the world of phenomena, of experience. The ethical law, which makes itself known in our practical reason, can, as we have seen earlier, receive no grounding at all according to Kant's doctrine. It speaks to us from a higher world than that of phenomena, absolutely independent as it is of all experience. In so far as man's will is determined by the ethical law, he is thus raised above the world of experience. Besides his empirical character, which can become an object of experience and observation, man therefore also has an "intelligible" character, according to which his action is guided by reason. "Reason itself," says Kant, "is no phenomenon and not subject to any of the conditions of

sensible experience." Through it man gains the capacity to act with absolute freedom, i.e. *[134]* independently of all motives and promptings given in experience.

One will see at once that Kant by no means assumes any decision or willing without a necessary cause. What he understands by freedom is a determination by ideal grounds (reason, duty) as opposed to determination by empirical grounds (the impulses, pleasure and pain). As regards the "intelligible" character too there is a necessary relation between motives and actions, for which reason Kant in his "Kritik der practischen Vernunft" (§ 6) sets himself the following problem: "Supposing that a will is free (sic), to find the law that alone is fit to determine it with necessity (sic)." He further investigates carefully "how the ethical law can become the incentive of the will," and finds that this happens through the feeling of respect and reverence. We have here, then, only another or higher kind of necessity, not freedom in the sense in which we have combated it above. We too have conceived freedom as an ideal that is not immediately given. The difference between our doctrine and Kant's consists in this, that he sees in freedom determined by reason something that lies beyond the world of experience, whereas the freedom of which we speak stands precisely as the goal of man's striving and development in the world of experience. We can console ourselves here with the thought that we show greater fidelity to Kant's philosophical principle than he does himself. His greatness rests on his having demonstrated the subjectivity of our knowledge and its limitation to experience. Only in the practical law of reason did he think he had an exception. *[135]* But by what right, then, does he call this law a "fact"? A fact must surely be accessible to experience. When he says that "reason itself is no phenomenon," how then does he come to know it, since experience, according to his own principle, is the only source of knowledge? And when he says that "reason is not subject to the conditions of sensible experience," how then can reason come into being and develop?[*)] We know no other reason than that which is the result of man's spiritual development in the world of experience. It is thus itself a phenomenon and must be conceived according to the laws valid for all experiences. The reason why Kant placed the ethical law of reason and freedom in another world than that of experience was their ideal character in relation to the other motives, capacities and powers in man. It is a remnant of dogmatism in Kant that he here considers it necessary to think of the ideal as existing. In reality, that man, ideally regarded, is free means nothing else than that it is his task and end to acquire freedom. What could it help that the ideal existed in a world beyond, if it could not be striven for and realized in the world we live in, the world of experience?

[*)]Kant here comes into contradiction with himself, since elsewhere (Kritik der pract. Vern. § 7 Anm. 2) he says that practical reason is "a naturally acquired capacity."

*[136]* If one should object to this that such an ideal cannot possibly be maintained, since experience constantly demonstrates our lack of freedom, it must be remarked that any ideal whatever by its nature points beyond reality. Without this opposition it would never come to action. The impulse to act arises through the idea of a state that is not present but whose image memory preserves; when conscious life has reached a certain development, the idea of a more perfect state takes the place of actual memory, and this is then, to be sure, often confused with actual memory; hence the myth of ideal innocence and happiness in a vanished paradise. Every impulse points beyond the given, and the ideal is the completed and harmonious expression of what already dawns partly and obscurely in the primitive manifestation of impulse; therefore it has its root in reality and yet leads beyond the reality given at any time. Only by building on the ground of determinism will ethics be able at once to maintain its ideal standpoint and to preserve its close connection with the real. Therefore great ethical thinkers too have sought to carry through the deterministic line of thought. Reference may be made here in particular to the English school (*Hume*, *Mill*, *Spencer*), *Herbart*, *Schleiermacher*, *Spinoza*, the *Stoics* and *Kant*, when we take him according to the spirit, not according to the letter.

*[137]* One must go back to the founder of humane ethics, *Socrates*, and the movement proceeding from him, to find the explanation of the difficulties in which the question of the freedom of the will has become entangled. Socrates led human action back to self-knowledge and maintained knowledge to be the essence of virtue. Passion became for him ignorance or incorrect knowledge. From this sprang the definition of the will which since *Plato* and *Aristotle* has been the prevailing one, while through Christian theology it also permeated the popular conception: the will is impulse guided by reason. Among the Greeks, in accordance with their whole naturalistic and aesthetic view of the world, the original endowment, the temperament and natural impulse were indeed always stressed as essentially intervening in and conditioning man's action. Plato derives all wickedness from a morbid bodily constitution and bad education and has a gaze, surprisingly sharp for his time, for the nature of insanity and its influence on the will. Aristotle holds fast to a happy natural endowment as a necessary presupposition for ethical development. But the Christian view of man in its severity took no account of such conditions. It regarded responsibility as man's innermost being. Even the obscure impulses and stirrings that dominate man before conscious life has developed to clarity and strength are regarded as sprung from a will that can be called to account. "All emotions," says *Augustine*, "are nothing but wills. For what are impulse and pleasure but will, in that we approve what we will? And what are fear and sorrow but will, in

that we abhor what we do not will?"[*)] "By the sensual, the carnal," says S. *Kierkegaard*,[**)] *[138]* "Christianity understands the selfish; nor can any conflict be thought between spirit and flesh unless there is a rebellious spirit on the side of the flesh, with which the spirit then strives; thus no conflict can be thought between spirit and a stone, or between spirit and a tree. Consequently the self-loving is the sensual." For the consistent Christian view there is hidden a will in every mental stirring in man, just as behind every natural event there lies a divine act of will. Here, then, two absolute freedoms come to stand over against each other, of which the one is the almighty, all-creating, over against which the other seems bound to become nothing. This difficulty, which the Apostle Paul strikes to the ground by holding up to man his absolute impotence (whereby he thus precisely concedes the difficulty), Augustine seeks in his acute way to solve by placing the will outside nature: "God is the author of all nature and all powers, but not of all wills. Evil has no nature; the evil will does not spring from any cause whatever: it is, after all, only through the will itself that evil comes into being!" If the will is not nature, it also lies beyond all corporeality. His chief objection to Plato's doctrine of the influence of bodily constitution on the will Augustine takes from the fact that the author of sin has *[139]* no body. The ultimate source of evil is a will without nature, which chooses evil with full knowledge and consciousness.[*)]

To such consequences one is led by holding fast to a conception of the will whereby an ideal state is immediately presupposed in man as an operative capacity at every stage of his development and in every situation in which he finds himself. We end here in the psychologically self-contradictory: for the full knowledge and consciousness of the nature of evil, which is a presupposition of the diabolical standpoint, would precisely make a willing of evil impossible. It is impossible that man, in one and the same spiritual state, should be able to choose the one just as well as the other of two opposite things. Pride, which is supposed to be the beginning of sin, and which consists in the self's choosing to be its own principle instead of having its principle in a higher power, has, just as much as any other trait of character, its natural origin, and the actions to which it leads spring forth according to the general psychological laws. The theological conception stops at the fact that the self wills to make itself the first and to withdraw from the relation to the higher power. The psychological conception goes further back and investigates why and how the self comes to will this. The value of *[140]* a poetic portrayal of a character rests on how far it gives us the full explanation of

[*)] De civitate dei. XIV, 6.
[**)] Kjærlighedens Gjerninger (3rd ed.) I, 60.
[*)] De civ. dei. V, 9; XI, 9; XII, 6; XIV, 3.

all decisions and actions. Even a character such as *Shakspeare's* Richard the Third, in which the poet has perhaps overstepped the limit of psychological truth and probability, finds its reconciling explanation in the very first speech. Contempt for the effeminacy and wretchedness around him, together with the feeling of his own bodily and mental ugliness, which makes it impossible for him to take part in the prevailing frivolous joy of life, while at the same time he feels within himself an energy that could overcome all barriers, and by which he stands high above those who regard him as an outcast, — all this begets the defiant resolve to play the devil's part:

"And therefore, since I cannot prove a lover,
To entertain these fair well-spoken days,
I am determined to prove a villain
And hate the idle pleasures of these days."

The poet has moreover clearly seen that in the psychological grounding one cannot stop at the single individual, but must go beyond it to the whole age and the preceding generations. Richard stands as the product of the struggles of the red and the white rose, of all the cruelty and treachery they begot. The passions have their natural history, and the ethical consideration cannot leap over all the intermediate links by which character and action first become intelligible, — intermediate links which are therefore
*[141]* properly parts of the very essence of character and action. A French author has said: tout comprendre, ce serait tout pardonner, and rightly, in so far as the action, by being seen in its necessity, no longer stands as the purely arbitrary. But although the ethical consideration cannot conflict with the psychological, it nevertheless does not coincide with it. In psychology we look back, seek the preceding causes, derive the later mental states from the earlier. In ethics we look forward, measure moods, decisions and actions against a certain model, and ask only about their harmonious or disharmonious relation to it. If it turns out that they do not accord with the norm, then the task becomes to find the cause of this discrepancy, and, when it is found, to investigate how far it is possible to clear this obstacle away.

*Hobbes* has aptly remarked that if the Aristotelian-scholastic definition of the will as rational impulse (appetitus rationalis) were correct, there could be no voluntary action that was contrary to reason. What this definition overlooks is that impulse as well as reason must run through a long development before they can unite and form rational will. One cannot therefore regard this as a capacity that belongs to everyone from the first, so that it depends on himself whether he will use it. In a certain sense man never acts against reason, namely against the reason he has at his disposal at the moment of

action; but he can act against the reason he ought to have, and which it is the goal of his striving to make his own. From the fact that one cannot, it does not follow that one shall not. Evil consists in man's being *not yet* good, not in his having ceased to be so. The degree of character and development of reason that man has attained can be obscured and diminished when the right motives and impulses are not maintained and when attention is dulled. But precisely this surely demonstrates that he has not yet attained such strength, coherence and consistency in his character that he can hold fast what he has acquired. We know, as already remarked, our character only from experience, and it is never concluded. Herein lies, on the other hand, also this, that we can never know with certainty whether we have used all our powers. As we are in many respects inclined to credit ourselves with too much, so here we perhaps think too little of what we are capable of. We must here say with Aladdin: "Whether I am master, a trial will show!" Only by the experimental way can we gain certainty here, as in so many other domains. If one should let oneself be deterred from such trials by the thought that they are of no use, since the necessary order of things goes its way in any case, one commits a fallacy to which logic has even given a special name ("lazy reason," ignava ratio), and which would correspond to deriving from the lawfulness of external nature that all our intervention in and action upon things was fruitless. Precisely because our willing and acting are links in the series of natural events can we modify them by altering the conditions under which they occur. *[142]* *[143]*

Human nature is in itself neither good nor evil. Concepts such as good and evil are relative concepts, which presuppose the application of a certain point of view, a certain standard. If we start from the fact that human nature is able to raise itself to a high degree of reason and freedom, of truth and love, we shall rightly call it good. If, on the other hand, we take account of the resistance that must be overcome and the struggle that must be endured for this goal to be reached, one can call it evil. The Christian doctrine of original sin and the Kantian doctrine of radical evil are from this point of view fully justified; only a smooth, superficial optimism can doubt it. The resistance that is offered, as well as the forces that work forward, spring from the nature of humanity. J. G. *Fichte* sought to show that radical evil consists in sluggishness, inertia. Just as in external nature there prevails a law of inertia, in that every thing persists in its present state as long as it is not carried beyond it by influences from without, so the human individual, without strong impulses from without, will not develop to freedom and truth. Therefore life in society, the intimate relation to the race, the whole historical side of human life, are so decisive for ethical life. Our earlier investigations have taught us

from several sides to recognize the necessity of education. Without the influence of
*[144]* authorities the spiritual growth of the human race would not take place. The history of humanity is essentially the history of authorities. In this great process of education the given, what has been attained hitherto, which has come into equilibrium and stiffens into fixed forms, offers resistance to the higher powers that are to work their way forward, just as every body offers resistance to another that would take its place. In the spiritual and especially in the ethical domain the higher power must moreover gain entrance through man's freedom, and we have seen that this consists in energetic attention and exertion; to this, then, man must first be awakened: the powers he is to use he cannot give himself, although he is to find them in his own nature. From sluggishness there develop not only cowardice and falseness, as Fichte has shown, but also defiance, the most intensive expression of inertia, which does not let itself be carried beyond itself to take part in the life of a larger whole. Defiance presupposes the less energetic forms of inertia, and only by here again making the end the beginning can one regard it as the source of sin. To overcome the resistance one must seek out the causes that originally brought development onto this path; one must here, as in all education, find motives and means whereby the isolation of the self can be abolished, its interest being attached to an essential, universally valid end.

Humane ethics, for which the golden age or paradise is not a lost good but a goal
*[145]* which, so far as is possible and justified under human conditions, is to be reached by the labor of the race, cannot regard sin or evil as something absolute. It knows a "not yet," not a "no more." It knows that the goal must by its nature lie beyond the given, and that there must therefore always be a distance between reality and ideal. This distance it takes as given and does not try to fill it out with the help of fantasy. Without such a distance, after all, it would not be worth living either. (For a similar reason Baggesen asked always to keep seven unfulfilled wishes in reserve). In so far as the distance is to be filled out in some other way than by ever-renewed striving, this filling out is the business of poetry, not of thought. But the distance must not be confused with irreconcilable opposition; on the contrary, the imperfections themselves pave the way for the more perfect. And the more evident it becomes that man really can make a contribution to the formation of his own character, and thereby also of that of the whole race, the more will interest also concentrate on this point, and the more detours and sufferings will be spared. An eminent English alienist, *Henry Maudsley*, has recently insisted on the importance of attention and interest for the development of character as a means of preserving from insanity. He sees in the weakening of character, in the general inclination to let oneself

be driven by the current instead of intervening self-actively, in great part the cause of the spread of insanity. But he stresses that a result is reached here slowly and perhaps first *[146]* becomes visible when the work is continued through a series of generations[*]. Insanity stands in close connection with the other evils under which humanity suffers; it is in itself only one of the forms under which the barriers to higher development appear. The rational doctrine of the freedom of the will which we have here attempted to maintain shows the possibility of moving these barriers, even if in the single case it were only by a hair's breadth. In ethics, as in other domains, we must often reckon with infinitely small quantities. It at the same time insists that this is possible only through penetrating psychological knowledge of character and its conditions, just as we also master external nature only by obedience to its laws. On the other hand, the assumption of an absolute freedom would easily lead to fantastic attempts to recreate oneself, to despair at not being able to, or to doubt of all lawful connection in the spiritual domain altogether.

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[*] See the fine concluding chapter of his book "Le crime et la folie". (Chap. IX: des moyens de se préserver de la folie).